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SCAN TO ENTER
THE WORLD OF SANSAAAR

Monday, August 31, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Who is liable for unsafe food sold by e-comm firms?

BY SAMIKSHA GOEL

Karnataka's food safety regulator earlier this week ordered the suspension of the food licences of major e-commerce platforms after officials found highly toxic datura fruits and seeds being listed and sold online as food products. *Mint* explains the development.



ISTOCKPHOTO

1 What is the concern around datura?

Datura contains potent tropane alkaloids such as atropine, scopolamine and hyoscyamine, which can disrupt the nervous system. Even relatively small amounts can cause dry mouth, blurred vision, rapid heartbeat, confusion, agitation, hallucinations, seizures and dangerously high body temperature. Severe poisoning can lead to coma or death. The risk is difficult to assess because the concentration of these compounds can vary across the plant. There is no safe basis for treating datura fruits or seeds as an ordinary food ingredient, which is why its listing is concerning.

MINT



2 Will the suspension impact platforms?

A food licence authorizes a business to carry out the food-related activities covered by that licence. So, in principle, a licence suspension means those activities cannot continue while the order is in force. The Karnataka order does not specify the particular licence numbers, premises or operations covered for Amazon, Swiggy Instamart and BigBasket. That makes it difficult to conclude that the companies have been forced to stop all food sales across the state. For now, they have been ordered to remove the listings and stop selling or distributing the plant as food and must submit compliance reports to the authorities.

3 Has this happened for the first time?

The datura episode appears unusually serious, but there are precedents for non-compliant food products sold online. In November 2025, Telangana food-safety officials inspected 75 warehouses of Zepto, Blinkit, BigBasket, Swiggy Instamart, Amazon and Flipkart, and seized 1,903 units of expired or misbranded food products.

4 Who is responsible in this case?

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India's (FSSAI's) rules place obligations on sellers and e-commerce food business operators: sellers must comply with food-safety rules and display licences, while platforms must have agreements requiring seller compliance, provide mandatory information to consumers and delist products that do not comply with laws. In this case, the answer may depend on how the product was listed, and checks performed and whether the platform knew it was being sold as food.

5 Have rules kept pace with quick commerce?

The spotlight is now on the gap between documentary compliance and actual product-level screening. How does a platform establish that every product, constantly changing online catalogue is safe and legally permissible to sell as food? It can verify a seller's FSSAI number and display information supplied by the seller, but that does not mean it has independently verified the identity, ingredients or intended use of every product. The datura case highlights a possible mismatch.

QUICK EDIT

Liability puzzles

Limited liability is regarded as a key innovation for its liberation of risky capital ventures from a business owner's fear of ruin. Long ago, the concept's failure to restrain shocking corporate actions, as in British East India Company's case, made rules of governance necessary. Today, Argentina's proposal to allow AI-run companies has revived a debate on whether limiting investor liability to the money they invest could be reckless. In India, the concept is rendered fuzzy by group structures with cross-subsidies woven into a web of listed and private entities under single control. Personal guarantees for loans have thus been part and parcel of India's credit market. This blurring of debt liability is legitimate, but can haunt insolvency cases. In the case of Essel Group's chief Subhash Chandra, for example, 'related-party lending' allegedly led to only a tiny fraction of his personally backed debt being approved for recovery by a creditor-panel vote. At one level, India's bankruptcy code might need yet another scan for a loophole-plugging exercise. At another, lenders must reduce the scope for confusion arising from personal guarantees, even as we ponder liability limits in the novel context of AI agency.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

Diversity is not a source of division; rather, it is a source of strength. It is our unity in diversity that makes Bharat truly unique and resilient.

C. P. RADHAKRISHNAN
VICE PRESIDENT



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THE WEEK AHEAD

31AUG-1SEP PM AT SCO SUMMIT

PM Modi to attend the 26th SCO Summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan

31AUG FM AT G20 FIN MEET

FM Sitharaman to lead India's delegation at G20 FMCBG meeting

1SEP DIGITAL IMMIGRATION

India to stop stamping physical boarding passes at immigration

3SEP TESLA'S CYBERCAB DEBUT

Tesla's steering-wheel-free Cybercab is set to debut in Austin, Texas

4SEP GOOGLE ASSISTANT ENDS

Google Assistant to stop working on Android, Gemini to take over

4SEP CHATGPT ADS IN INDIA

OpenAI to launch ChatGPT ads, give Ads Manager platform access

m COLUMNS



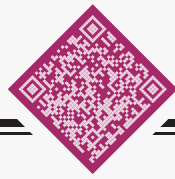
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Saumitra Bhaduri
THE RUPEE HAS
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THE ECONOMICS OF PRIVATIZED AIRPORTS

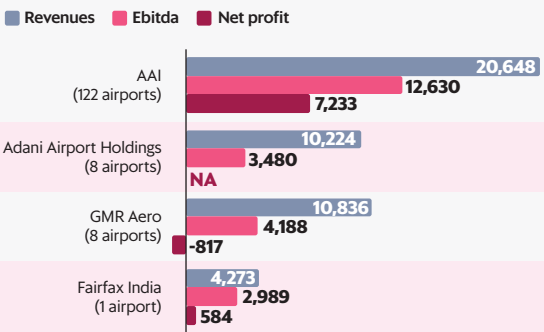
BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Earlier this month, the Union government proposed to privatize 11 more airports via the public-private partnership (PPP) route. This comes exactly 20 years after Delhi and Mumbai became the first Indian airports to be privatized, followed by another lot of six airports in 2020-21.

The experience of these older airports shows that the PPP route has benefited all stakeholders — the government, private airport operators and consumers. While the 11 airports to be offered next are significantly smaller than the previous lot in terms of passenger traffic, operational scale and future possibilities, expectations from this exercise will be similar: to unlock value in airports currently owned and operated by the government.

Indian airport operators are making money at the operational level

Key financials of Indian airport operators (in ₹ crore), 2024-25



Ebitda: Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization. GMR Aero's portfolio includes 2 foreign airports. Net profit figure is not available for Adani Airport Holdings

Source: Annual reports of AAI and GMR Aero, Adani Airport Holdings presentation, Ica



APPETITE FOR CAPITAL

THE AIRPORTS Authority of India (AAI) is the government organization that owns and operates 122 airports in India. It also previously managed the eight airports privatized so far. Besides AAI, the airport sector in India has two large private operators—the Adani Group (which operates 8 airports, including Mumbai) and the GMR Group (8 airports, including Delhi). They are all making money at the operational level.

Unlike GMR Aero, AAI is also profitable at a net level. In 2024-25, it posted a net profit of ₹7,233 crore on revenues of ₹20,648 crore—a net margin of 35%.

It would appear that AAI is generating adequate surpluses to modernize and expand its airports by itself. However, the business of airports is such that even ₹5,568 crore—AAI's capital expenditure in 2024-25—can't support the sector's large capital needs. For context, the first phase of the new Noida airport reportedly cost ₹11,200 crore.

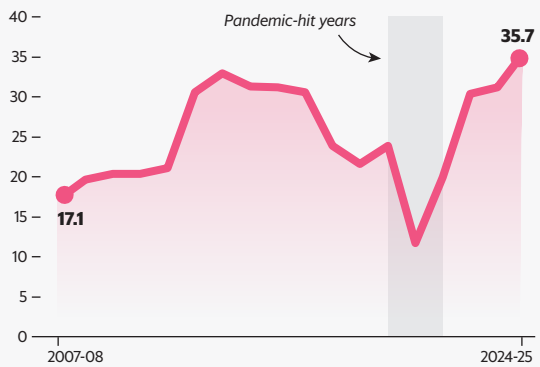
REVENUE SHARING

THE OTHER reason to get the private sector involved is the face lift it can provide to these airports. Delhi and Mumbai are good examples of the transformation of airports and all services around them. Even when AAI hands out these airports in the PPP mode, it remains a stakeholder and a beneficiary. In Delhi and Mumbai, which were awarded on effectively a 60-year lease, AAI has a 26% stake and receives a share of revenues annually.

For the six airports handed out in 2020-21 on a 50-year lease (Ahmedabad, Guwahati, Jaipur, Lucknow, Mangaluru and Thiruvananthapuram), AAI receives a fee per passenger. For the next proposed lot of 11 airports, the government is looking at a 50-year agreement, again with AAI receiving a fee per passenger. It was in 2012-13 that such income from airports operated by private players on a PPP basis crossed 30% of AAI's income. This figure started falling in 2017-18 as agreements were redrawn. It fell further during the covid pandemic, but is now back above 30% again.

More than 30% of AAI's revenues come from airports run by private companies

Share of income in revenues of the Airports Authority of India from privatized airports (in %)

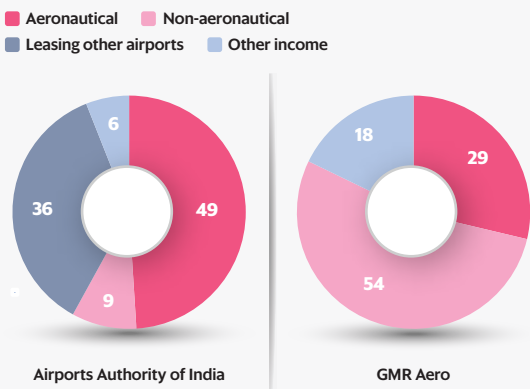


Source: Airports Authority of India annual reports



Non-aero sources contributed over 50% to GMR's revenues, only 9% of AAI's

Revenue breakup (in %), 2024-25



Source: Company annual reports



BEYOND FLIGHTS

IN ONE sense, the PPP arrangement has its benefits. The private sector brings in the investment to modernize and expand the airport and tap other commercial possibilities around it. That improvement in scale, upkeep and services leads to more flights and passengers. That translates to higher revenues for the private operator—and, by extension, for AAI.

Broadly, an airport's revenues can be placed in two categories: aeronautical and non-aeronautical. Aero sources principally consist of landing and parking charges paid by airlines, passenger service fees and user development fees. Non-aero sources are principally income from giving space to retail outlets, taxi services, vehicle parking, ground handling and cargo handling. A third category is commercial development of land.

Private operators have shown better prospects than the government operator at tapping non-aero revenue streams: in 2024-25, 54% of GMR Aero's revenues came from non-aero sources, against only 9% for AAI.

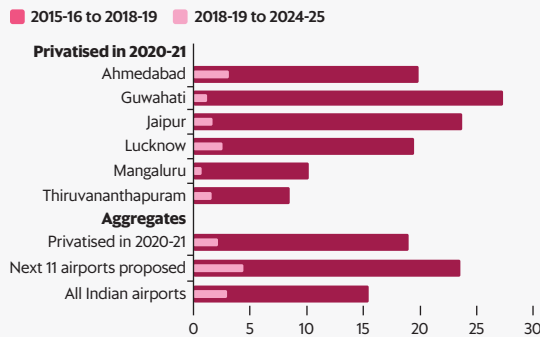
COVID BREAK

THE BUOYANCY in non-aero revenues is one reason why GMR Aero stock has delivered a compounded annual return of about 30% in the past five years, against about 7% by the BSE Sensex. This is also the period when the aviation sector rebounded from the shutdown of the covid pandemic. But the recovery has been gradual, and the six airports that were privatized in 2020-21—all bagged by the Adani Group—got caught up in the pandemic crosshairs.

Before the pandemic, Indian aviation was buzzing. In the three-year period from 2015-16 to 2018-19, total passenger traffic increased at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 15.5%. These six airports grew at 19%. Post-covid, most crossed 2018-19 (pre-covid) passenger levels only in 2023-24 or 2024-25. Thus, in the six-year period to 2024-25, they all show a significant drop in growth rates. This is also the case with the proposed set of 11 airports, whose CAGR in passengers plunged from 23.6% to 4.4% over the same period.

Covid became a significant break-point in passenger growth at Indian airports

Compound annual growth rate in passenger footfall* (in %)



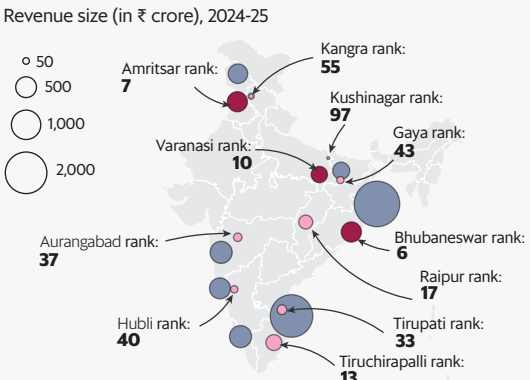
*Includes both domestic and international. 2024-25 has been taken as the latest year since 2025-26 data, though available, was distorted due to the impact of the US-Iran war on air travel.

Source: Airports Authority of India



Only 3 of the 11 AAI airports proposed to be privatized are among its 10 biggest

Top 10 under AAI (to be privatized) To be privatized



Source: Airports Authority of India



LONG TAIL

THE 11 airports are proposed to be offered as five bundles, pairing a mid-sized/profitable airport with a smaller/loss-making one: Tiruchirappalli and Tirupati; Bhubaneswar and Hubballi; Amritsar and Kangra-Gaggal; Varanasi, Gaya and Kushinagar; and Raipur and Aurangabad. A cap is proposed on how many bundles an operator can get. These 11 airports handled 19.4 million passengers in 2024-25, about half the 39.3 million handled in 2024-25 by the 6 previously privatized airports. This drop-off also shows AAI's long tail: of its 122 airports, only 32 were profitable in 2024-25, including four in this lot. Three of them (Bhubaneswar, Amritsar, Varanasi) are among its top 10 by revenue. Of the airports still with AAI, Kolkata and Chennai are the largest. Last week Tamil Nadu scrapped the chosen site of Chennai's 2nd airport, turning back to its AAI airport to manage growth. For all the upsides of PPP, its runway is still long. www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

STRAIGHT
FORWARD
SHASHI SHEKHARRespond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

GIG WORK INDUSTRY HAS DEHUMANIZED INDIA'S WORKFORCE

The incident happened just before *Raksha Bandhan*. The society gate called to inform *Mehdi Wallah* had arrived. My daughter scheduled him through an app for 8:30pm, but he was running two hours late. When we opened the door, we encountered an overworked, exhausted man in front of us. We could gather he was in no position, physically or mentally, to perform this delicate task. My daughter offered him water and asked why he was so late.

He cracked under the emotional weight, complaining of overwork, long hours and constant threat of bad ratings. "When I used to work in the village, the earnings were less, but people respected me. Now, it seems I have turned into a machine," he said.

Overwhelmed by his plight, my wife and daughter offered him dinner, but he declined with humility.

Our metropolises have turned into mirages where everyone is condemned to wander aimlessly. In the festive season, companies have initiated fresh hiring of gig workers. Companies providing such work expect to create 15-20%, or 250,000-300,000, more jobs.

The trend isn't restricted to metropolitan cities. Even small towns, hilly towns and people living in the deep interior need more hands. However, we shouldn't forget that these hirings are transient. The moment festive demand subsides, jobs will vanish too.

Companies hiring gig workers operate on the principle of 'use and throw'. As soon as the festive and discount seasons of big companies end, incentives for the delivery partners are discontinued. Their app doesn't provide them with new delivery stalls, and using technical jargon blocks their IDs.

Gig work has dealt a body blow to the humane side of employment. Even those who are constantly engaged in earning a living are subjected to inhuman stress. The pressure to deliver on time forces them to drive rashly, leading to accidents. According to Niti Aayog, 27% of gig workers in the country experience minor or major accidents. Muscle pain and other issues from constantly driving with heavy loads are common problems. Muscle soreness demands physical rest. However, if you don't log in to the app for an extended period, you risk being blocked.

Still, gig workers are increasing by the day. There were 7.7 million gig workers in India in 2021, according to Niti Aayog. In the last four years, the workforce has grown by 55%. The federal think tank estimates that over the next four years, the number will reach 23 million, accounting for 6.7% of the non-agriculture workforce.

We need to keep in mind that 22-23% of this workforce is concentrated in the National Capital Region. Today, apart from Amazon, Zomato, Flipkart, and Swiggy, there are many regional apps that reach deep into the interiors and high mountains.

This new work culture has changed the face of the Indian labour market. Sparkling uniforms, clean taxis or bikes and direct bank transfers for quick payments look quite attractive from a distance. But it's the illusion of formalization.

It has severed the human cord that held the humans and their work together. Earlier, there was a personal touch between the employer and employee. If need arose, the 'malik' would give an advance or help the worker meet medical emergencies. Today, labour management is hijacked by the opaque black box of algorithms. These algorithms decide who will earn and to what extent.

Gig workers also serve as useful tools for hiding actual unemployment. Many times, people with higher degrees turn to this work in the absence of any credible employment, as they don't want to be labelled unemployed in society. Another dark side to the whole affair is the critical shortage of workers it's creating in agriculture and small industries.

There's a huge social angle to it, too. Unemployed young don't want to do 'small jobs' near their homes or their villages. Instead, they are willing to head to big cities and work in inhuman conditions of excessive duty.

It's clear that problems for gig workers are piling up faster than the rate at which the number of gig workers is increasing. It's time that, like Europe, in India too, we make tough laws and regulations to safeguard gig workers' economic and social security. Rajasthan has shown the way. It's time for the Centre and other states to carry the baton.

A progressive society runs on policies and regulations, and not on algorithms.

Shashi Shekhar is the editor-in-chief of *Hindustan*. Views are personal.

Chemical exporters may get sops to cut US dependence

The proposed measures will focus on helping exporters identify and access new markets

Harsh Kumar
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NEW DELHI

The Centre may soon offer policy support and financial incentives to encourage geographic diversification in India's chemical exports, according to two people aware of the development.

The proposed measures, part of an effort to reduce dependence on the US market, will focus on helping exporters identify and access new markets while strengthening India's integration and position in global chemical value chains, these people added.

The US accounts for 18% of India's chemical exports, underscoring the need to broaden the export base and reduce concentration in a single market, the first of the two people cited above said. Encouraging greater exports across Europe, Southeast Asia, West Asia, Africa and Latin America could help diversify export destinations, reduce geographic concentration risks and build a more resilient export ecosystem for India's chemical industry, the person added.

A product-region approach could allow the country to target specific chemical categories based on demand and competitive opportunities in individual markets, according to the people cited above. "Agrochemicals, water-treatment and



To build long-term momentum, government think tank Niti Aayog has targeted scaling annual chemical exports to \$81 billion by 2030.

MINT

construction chemicals could be targeted in African markets, while Latin America could offer opportunities for agrochemicals, specialty chemicals, dyes and pigments. Asean markets could be explored for surfactants, polymers and industrial intermediates, while Europe could offer opportunities in specialty, green and pharmaceutical chemicals," the first person said.

Official data underscores the sector's shifting export trajectory over recent years. According to DGCIIS (directorate general of commercial intelligence and statistics) figures submitted to the Rajya Sabha by the minister of state for chemicals and

fertilizers, India's chemical exports rose sharply from ₹2,79,337 crore in fiscal year 2021 (FY21) to ₹3,68,597 crore in FY22—a growth of nearly 32%. Growth slowed to 3.2% in FY23 (₹3,80,493 crore) before contracting 2.1% in FY24 (₹3,72,535 crore). Exports bounced back in FY25, rising 5.4% to reach ₹3,92,769 crore.

To build long-term momentum, government think tank Niti Aayog has targeted scaling annual chemical exports to \$81 billion by 2030. This includes \$45 billion from specialty chemicals, \$26 billion from petrochemicals, and \$5-10 billion from inorganic chemicals. The initiative forms part of a

broader vision to move India toward a net-zero importer stance by FY30 while expanding the overall industry scale toward \$1 trillion by 2040.

Such a strategy could also support the industry's transition from relatively lower-value bulk chemicals towards higher-value, application-specific products, allowing Indian manufacturers to move into more profitable segments.

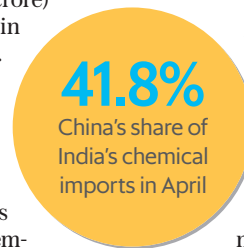
To lower reliance on the US, India must adopt a targeted product-region export strategy, according to Dr Ram Singh, professor and head at IIFT, New Delhi. "Simultaneously, India must shift from bulk chemicals to higher-value, application-specific products to enter higher-profit segments," he said.

On the import side, India faces significant supply-chain risks due to heavy reliance on a single market. China accounted for 41.8% (\$560 million) of India's \$1.34 billion organic chemical imports in April 2026, a sharp rise from 29.4% a year ago.

"Diversifying sourcing geographies and encouraging alternative supply chains could therefore improve supply security and reduce concentration risks," the second person said.

Mint's queries emailed to spokespersons for the ministry of finance, the ministry of commerce and industry, and the department of chemicals and petrochemicals remained unanswered.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)



'Women 46% beneficiaries of street-vendor credit scheme'

Manas Pimpalkhare
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NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said women account for 46% of beneficiaries under the PM SVANidhi scheme, which provides street vendors with credit for business expansion.

As many as 3.5 million women have received benefits under this 2020 scheme, Modi said during his monthly address to the nation, *Mann Ki Baat*.

He said lakhs of women run tea stalls, sell vegetables, fruits and earthen lamps. "Often, a mere lack of capital prevents their businesses from growing further... around 35 lakh (3.5 million) women across the country are expanding their businesses by connecting with this scheme," he said.

According to the scheme's portal, there are 7.8 million beneficiaries under the PM SVANidhi scheme, for which the government has disbursed ₹19,203 crore since its launch in 2020.

The PM also called upon cit-



As many as 3.5 million women received benefits under the scheme, PM Modi said.

PTI

izens to support the government's campaign to protect the youth from drug addiction. "The 'Nasha-mukt Yuva for Viksit Bharat' campaign is currently gaining momentum rapidly across the country. Its goal is absolutely clear: drug-free youth; a drug-free India," he said.

This comes in the wake of a massive mobilization of the youth in New Delhi on 20 July, demanding education reforms, which eventually led to the resignation of the then

Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Modi also urged content creators to record in various languages to help in the endeavour to rid society of the issue of drug addiction. "Our country has no shortage of excellent content creators. I urge them to create content in various languages that helps society in this endeavour."

He also reiterated the need to be 'vocal for local', a call to purchase homegrown products. "Whatever item we purchase for our homes, do ensure to see that it is made in India. The path to India becoming self-reliant will be paved only by taking pride in products made in India," the PM said.

The PM also said cultivating avocados locally has provided additional income to many farmers at a time when the fruit has become a preferred choice in the health and premium markets.

"...the avocado from our own country has enhanced the taste of your toast while simultaneously boosting the farmers' income."

Govt plans to triple raw material assistance for MSMEs by FY30

Manas Pimpalkhare & Rituraj Baruah
NEW DELHI

The Union ministry of micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSME) plans to triple the volume of raw materials it assists MSMEs in procuring through state-run National Small Industries Corp. (NSIC) to about 900,000 tonnes a year by fiscal year 2030 (FY30), from around 300,000 tonnes currently, as businesses grapple with supply disruptions and procurement constraints, according to two government officials aware of the development.

NSIC runs the raw material assistance and raw material distribution schemes for MSMEs, under which it aggregates demand for various raw materials and procures them at lower rates. The schemes cover products ranging from metals and coal to construction materials.

The bulk procurement can lower commodity prices by 3-5%, while also helping MSMEs save on supply-chain costs, according to MSME



Bulk procurement lowers raw material prices by 3-5% to save supply-chain costs. ISTOCKPHOTO

industry estimates.

"We have NSIC, which aggregates demand for various commodities and gets lower prices. That is expected to increase, NSIC is targeting around 9 lakh tonnes (900,000) of commodities per year by FY30, from the current 3 lakh (300,000) tonnes volume," one of the officials said.

NSIC distributed 364,374 tonnes of raw material worth ₹3,089 crore in 2025 under the Raw Material Distribution Scheme, according to the MSME ministry's FY26 annual

report. The state-run corporation also provided credit worth ₹7,841 crore to 2,440 businesses between January and November 2025 for raw material procurement under the schemes, according to MSME ministry data.

Mint's queries emailed to the MSME ministry and NSIC remained unanswered.

The push to expand the scheme comes as MSMEs face growing procurement challenges. A survey of 27,045 MSMEs by industry lobby group India SME Forum in early August found that 55% of respondents faced issues related to price volatility or a lack of transparency in procurement prices.

The report, titled India MSME Digital Procurement Report 2026, also found that 68.7% of surveyed MSMEs wanted to procure raw materials digitally, while 55.7% identified price volatility as a major procurement challenge.

India has 92 million MSMEs, according to government data.

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India sets minimum standards for mortuaries, bans basement morgues

Priyanka Sharma
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NEW DELHI

India recently introduced its first national minimum standards for mortuary and post-mortem infrastructure, finalized by the National Council for Clinical Establishments under the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), setting uniform requirements for cold storage, staffing, body identification and autopsy facilities while barring morgues from basements and areas near hospital waste disposal sites.

The standards seek to

replace a fragmented system in which mortuary operations have largely been governed by state police manuals and medico-legal codes rather than uniform technical requirements, according to two government officials and the 'Clinical Establishment Act Standards for Mortuary' document reviewed by *Mint*.

Implementation will be the responsibility of state and Union territory authorities.

The new framework requires mortuaries to maintain dead-body cold storage at 4°C to 8°C, with a minimum capacity of four bodies, and to keep medico-legal case (MLC)



The standards are to replace a fragmented system governed by state police manuals and medico-legal codes.

MINT

bodies separate from non-MLC remains. Each body must also be assigned a unique serial number, which must be

reflected on the storage cabin, to prevent mix-ups and ensure traceability.

The framework applies to

both public and private hospitals in states and Union territories that have adopted the Clinical Establishments Act, according to the health ministry.

The standards come against the backdrop of uneven forensic infrastructure in India, where functional post-mortem facilities are largely concentrated in tertiary government medical colleges and district civil hospitals. India records more than 8.6 million registered deaths a year, according to official Civil Registration System data.

The standards link staffing directly to the annual autopsy workload. A mortuary han-

dling up to 100 autopsies a year must have two registered medical practitioners, preferably with an MD in forensic medicine, two post-mortem technicians and two post-mortem assistants, along with support staff including a clerk, security guards, a peon and morgue attendants. For every additional 100 autopsies a year, the establishment must add another doctor, technician and assistant; an official photographer is listed as desirable, according to the framework.

Mortuary complexes must be located on the ground floor and have dedicated, segregated entry points to keep the move-

ment of bodies separate from general patient traffic. The standards also bar mortuaries from being located near hospital refuse or dumping areas.

"The site of the mortuary should be selected after taking into account the lighting, ventilation and isolation on the ground floor. Mortuary should be located either at one end or slightly away from main hospital building, but never be located in the basement or around the refuse or dumping area of the hospital waste," according to the standards document.

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NPCI to make UPI auto-pay interoperable across apps

Users can switch apps without recreating auto-pay mandates; merchants can switch gateways

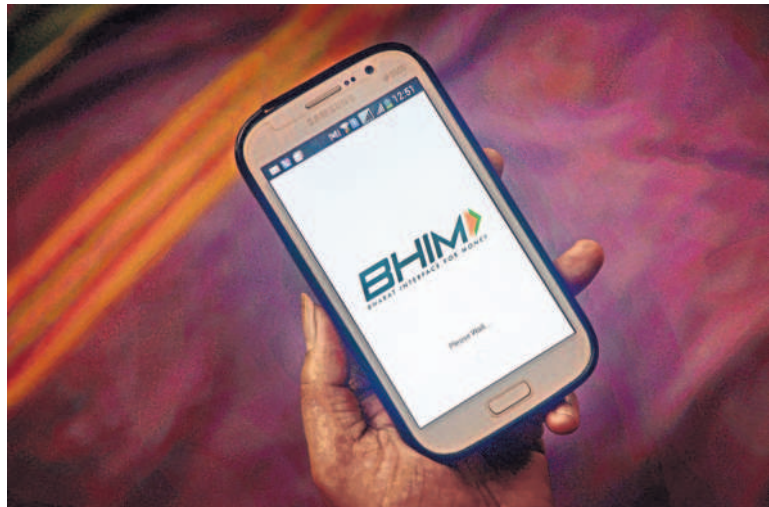
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MUMBAI

The National Payments Corp. of India (NPCI) is set to make UPI auto-pay interoperable, allowing users to port recurring payment instructions across apps and merchants to move existing mandates from one payment gateway to another, four people aware of the development said.

The move could reduce two forms of lock-ins in the recurring-payments market. Consumers will be able to shift existing auto-pay mandates to another UPI app instead of cancelling and recreating subscriptions, insurance premiums, systematic investment plans (SIPs) or loan repayments, while merchants will be able to move existing mandates to another payment provider when they switch gateways.

For users, a cross-app view of mandates could also make it easier to track upcoming debits, account balances and forgotten subscriptions. Both features could be announced at the Global Fintech Fest in Mumbai next month, one of the people said.

Importantly, mandates linked to different customer bank accounts will continue to be debited from the account originally authorised by the user. The interoperability change instead allows eligible mandates to be accessed across UPI apps, while merchants can shift them to a new acquiring bank or payment gateway without requiring customers to



Consumers could switch UPI apps without cancelling and recreating mandates for subscriptions, insurance premiums, SIPs and loan repayments.

register afresh.

NPCI launched UPI auto-pay in 2020 to let businesses automatically debit a customer's bank account at fixed intervals for subscriptions, loan

for a while, the people cited above said.

The scale of recurring payments has also grown. NPCI data showed that the top 10 banks cumulatively processed nearly 1.8 billion UPI e-mandate trans-

actions executive at a large UPI app said seeking anonymity. "Smaller apps wanted what they call a level playing field. They feel auto-pay is a way in which people become locked into an app. Generally, an auto-pay customer will be more sticky, because if you've set it up, there is always that fatigue of moving apps. So the smaller apps felt that it makes the consumer captive."

Many users install a UPI app for cash-backs and offers, set up an auto-pay mandate and then have little reason to change apps because their recurring payments are linked to the platform. If mandates can be viewed and ported across apps, that advantage could weaken, giving newer apps such as Navi, POP UPI and super.money a better chance of attracting users whose recurring payments are currently managed through larger UPI apps like PhonePe or Google Pay.

The change, however, requires work across the ecosystem. "All the apps also have to make changes to enable this, because it has to be across apps," the executive said, adding that his own company had made those changes. Queries to NPCI didn't elicit any response till press time.

For merchants, interoperability means their existing base of mandates becomes portable. Currently, a subscription business that switches payment gateways can route new customers through the new partner, but its older mandates remain with the original provider.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Country Delight warms up for \$200-300 million IPO

Agnidev Bhattacharya & Priyamvada C.

MUMBAI

Country Delight's parent has begun early-stage preparations for an initial public offering (IPO) in India that could raise \$200-300 million, as the subscription-based dairy and fresh-produce delivery platform weighs a listing within the next 12-18 months, said two people familiar with the matter.

Beejapuri Dairy Pvt. Ltd. will begin informal pitches to investment bankers over the next 7-10 days to select lead managers for the proposed IPO, one of the people said.

The IPO is likely to comprise a combination of fresh equity and an offer for sale by existing institutional shareholders, a second person said. The final issue size, primary-secondary split and timing will depend on the board's approval and stock market conditions, this person added.

They said that Country Delight is also evaluating a potential pre-IPO fundraise to establish a valuation benchmark before filing its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi). Both refused to be identified as the details are private.

An email query to Country Delight on 28 August did not elicit a response till press time. Started in 2015 by Indian



IPO is likely to combine fresh equity and offer for sale; the issue size, mix and timing will depend on board approval.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Institute of Management (IIM) Indore graduates Chakradhar Gade and Nitin Kaushal, the firm operates a direct-to-consumer supply chain for perishable food. The Gurugram-headquartered company sources milk, dairy products, fruits and vegetables directly from farmers and processing facilities

and delivers them to urban households via an integrated supply network. Country Delight currently operates across metropolitan Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad and Chennai. Users place or modify subscription orders through its mobile app before midnight for early-morning delivery.

Country Delight has also expanded beyond its core subscription model. In late 2024, it entered quick commerce through a pilot offering 10-15-minute deliveries, putting it in competition with Eternal Ltd's

Blinkit, Swiggy Ltd's Instamart and Zepto Ltd.

The company raised ₹65 crore in debt from Alteria Capital in May this year, with the funds earmarked for general corporate purposes. In March 2025, it had raised ₹200 crore (around \$25 million) in equity from Singapore state investor Temasek Holdings Pte. An Entracker report said the round valued Country Delight at \$820 million, unchanged from its previous valuation, and that Temasek had become its largest external investor with around 13% stake.

Other investors include Venturi Partners, Orios Venture Partners, Matrix Partners, IIFL Asset Management and Elevation Capital.

Mint had reported in April 2025 that Country Delight was seeking to raise up to \$100 million, with some existing investors looking to sell their stakes to incoming investors.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Nasa's Roman telescope set to bring wider view of cosmos

Reuters
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Nasa's new flagship astronomical observatory was launched into space from Florida on Sunday on a mission to probe some of the biggest mysteries in astrophysics and cosmology.

The Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, a roughly \$4 billion project, was carried aloft from Nasa's Kennedy Space Center aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket.

The telescope is designed to investigate cosmic enigmas such as dark energy and dark matter, while also testing gravity at vast scales and searching for exoplanets, as planets beyond our solar system are called. There were also some weather concerns ahead of the launch but the rocket carried the telescope into space through blue skies and some scattered clouds.

Roman will travel through space toward an orbital location called Lagrange Point 2, situated about a million miles (1.6 million km) from Earth. Its mission is planned for five years, though the U.S. space agency said the telescope may have enough fuel for five additional years.

Roman will build on the capabilities of other orbiting observatories such as the James Webb Space Telescope, launched in 2021, and the Hubble Space Telescope, launched in 1990. "It will be as if Hubble and James Webb kind of peered through a keyhole at the universe, while Nancy Grace Roman will kick the door down," Nicola Fox, chief of Nasa's Science Mission Directorate, told reporters on Saturday.

"Roman has broadly the same sensitivity and sharpness of vision as Hubble, but we survey the sky much faster," Julie McNery, Roman's senior project scientist at Nasa's Goddard Space Flight Center in Maryland, told reporters at a briefing in July.

McNery said one month of Roman observations can survey our entire home galaxy. "One month of observations



Nasa launched its flagship observatory, the \$4 bn Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy.

REUTERS

to survey our Milky Way galaxy would take about a century with Hubble," McNery said.

Webb has provided a new understanding of the early history of the universe, finding among other things that primordial galaxies formed sooner and were bigger than previously known. Webb is capable of looking across vast distances and back into deep time, because of the time it takes light to travel.

Roman instead is able to take panoramic views. Nasa likens Roman to a camera's wide-angle lens and Webb to a zoom lens.

"Webb is designed to be able to probe very deeply and with exquisite sensitivity into the universe, so we can find rare things in the early universe," McNery said, while Roman offers "the large vision that complements the deep views that Webb provides."

Roman will help in the understanding of two mysterious cosmic components — dark energy and dark matter — by creating the most comprehensive 3D map of the universe to date. Its main survey, to take more than a year to complete, will cover more than two billion galaxies.

The Big Bang event roughly 13.8 billion years ago initiated the universe, and it has been expanding ever since. Scientists in 1998 disclosed that this expansion was actually accelerating, with an invisible force

called dark energy as the hypothesized reason.

The universe's contents include ordinary matter — stars, planets, gas, dust and all the familiar stuff on Earth — as well as dark matter and dark energy. Ordinary matter represents perhaps 5% of the contents. Dark matter, known through its gravitational influences on galaxies and stars, may represent about 27%. Dark energy may represent about 68%.

Using Roman to gauge dark matter's pull and dark energy's push across the universe will bring scientists closer than ever before to solving both mysteries, according to Nasa.

Roman also will conduct one of the most comprehensive searches ever for exoplanets. It is expected to discover thousands of new ones and provide the first statistical census of planetary systems similar to our own.

"One of the most exciting aspects of Roman is its discovery potential. Historically, major astronomical observatories have often made their most important breakthroughs in areas that scientists did not anticipate before launch," cosmologist Mustafa Ishak of the University of Texas at Dallas, a member of Roman's scientific collaboration, told Reuters.

President Donald Trump's administration tried during both his first and second terms to reduce or eliminate funding for Roman, but Congress preserved it. Roman's launch comes nine months ahead of schedule, according to Nasa.

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NEW DELHI

State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1% stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through the exchange's proposed ₹30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The bank is participating in the NSE IPO and will dilute a 0.65% stake in the exchange,

SBI chairman C.S. Setty told PTI in an interview. "We are participating in that divestment. We propose to divest 0.65% and 0.35% by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1% as a SBI group... it could be less, depending on any other shareholders joining," he said.

SBI now holds 3.23% in NSE, while SBI Capital Markets owns 4.33% in the country's largest stock exchange.

He clarified that there is no

the monetization plan for other subsidiaries in the immediate future.

Last month, SBI, along with its foreign partner Paris-headquartered Amundi, diluted around 10% stake in SBI Mutual Fund. The ₹9,800-crore public offer by the country's biggest fund house was a huge success as the issue was subscribed 42 times.

Post-listing, SBI's holding declined to 55.46% from 61.76%, while Amundi's stake reduced to 32.56%, down 3.7%.

Speaking on SBI's leadership position in home finance, Setty said the mortgage portfolio is set to cross an important milestone of ₹10 trillion on the back of robust demand.

The country's largest lender's home loan portfolio had topped ₹9 trillion in the last financial year. "We should be reaching the ₹10 trillion mark, hopefully in this quarter itself," he said. SBI has a market share of nearly 28% in the home loan segment, he said. The lender has more than

460 home loan processing centres across India, increasing accessibility of its housing finance products.

Setty said transparency in pricing and customer trust in its processes, including documentation and due diligence of builders, are among the factors driving its home loan arm. "People trust SBI most when it comes to taking a home loan... as a segment is very important for the economy," Setty said, noting that over 200 industries depend on real estate.

MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

Understanding growth and income distribution, capital withdrawal (IDCW) options in mutual funds

smarTomorrows by **CANARA ROBECO** Mutual Fund
An Investor education and awareness initiative

IDCW options simply handle the same investment gains differently.

Under the Growth option, gains remain invested in the fund and continue participating in future market movements. This allows compounding to work over time.

Under the IDCW option, the fund may distribute money to



investors from time to time, subject to availability and applicable rules and

regulations. Since money leaves the fund, the NAV adjusts accordingly. Refer to the table below.

Consider a simple example: Suppose two investors each invest ₹1 lakh in the same fund. One chooses the Growth option and the other chooses IDCW payout option. If the IDCW option distributes ₹10,000 over time, that amount is paid out and the

fund value adjusts accordingly. In Growth, the same value remains invested and continues compounding.

Mr Investor: So, does that mean Growth is always better?

Mr Mutual Fund: Not necessarily. The right choice depends on your objective. If your focus is long-term accumulation, Growth may align better. If you prefer receiving periodic distributions, IDCW may suit your needs. The key is understanding that distributions are not additional returns.

Mr Investor: I've seen people compare funds only based on IDCW history. Should I do that?

Mr Mutual Fund: It's better to avoid selecting funds solely based on payouts. Focus first on your goal, investment horizon, and cash flow needs. Understanding the difference between Growth and IDCW helps investors make informed choices. Both options have a role, the right one depends on how you want your investments to work for you.

Aspect	Growth Option	IDCW Payout Option
Treatment of Gains	Earnings accumulated into the fund	Earnings paid to the investor or reinvested into the fund based on the option selected
Compounding Benefit	Higher potential as the earnings are accumulated	Reduced as payouts happen
Cash Flow	No periodic payouts	Can provide periodic distributions, subject to availability of distributable surplus and in accordance with applicable regulations
NAV Movement	Reflects retained gains	Adjusts after distribution
Suitable For	Long-term wealth creation	Investors seeking periodic cash flow

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.
Disclaimer: Know Your Customer (KYC) is mandatory to complete KYC process before investing in Mutual Funds (MF). For this, submit the completed KYC Form at any Asset Management Company (AMC) branch or nearest Point of Service (POS) or through a financial advisor. For KYC Form, click link: <https://www.canararobeco.com/web-content/uploads/2025/02/cr-central-kyc-registry-application-form-individual.pdf>. If you would like to update any KYC information (address, contact details etc.), submit the KYC Form with updated details at your nearest AMC branch or POS. Check KYC status at www.karykya.com. For change of bank details registered with any MF, download bank mandate change form from that MF's website, and submit the form to that MF's branches or Official Points of Acceptance. SBI Registered Mutual Funds: Investors should deal only with registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified on the SBI website under "Investment/Market Infrastructure Institutions" at <https://www.sbi.co.in/investments>. Complaint Redressal: For complaints, contact the Investor Service Department of the respective MF. For contact details, refer scheme related documents (SRI). In case, the investor is not satisfied with the resolution, the investor can complain on SCORES platform (SBI Complaints Redress System) at <https://scores.sbi.co.in>. For cases, where the investor is not satisfied with the resolution by AMFC/MF or through SCORES, the investor can complain on Online Dispute Resolution Portal ("ODR Portal") at <https://smarTomorrows.in/login>. This material is a part of the Investor Education and Awareness Initiative by Canara Robeco Mutual Fund. SBI Registered Name: Canara Robeco Mutual Fund SBI Registration Number: MF/004/93/4

S&P BSE Sensex			Nifty 50			Nifty 500			Nifty Next 50			Nifty 100			S&P BSE Mid-cap			S&P BSE Small Cap		
CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)		CLOSE	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	
77,264.51	-0.36		24,175.65	-0.31		23,528.55	0.00		74,159.15	0.25		25,341.75	-0.21		17,335.13	0.31		7,279.53	0.52	
1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)		1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	
0.80	2.66		0.95	1.89		1.96	3.10		3.09	3.74		1.34	2.23		2.92	4.32		4.41	7.27	
6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)		6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	
-3.91	-2.11		-3.02	0.06		2.41	5.66		7.37	14.10		-1.18	2.48		8.88	12.14		16.12	10.57	



The leadership change comes as HDFC Bank has become a favourite of domestic mutual funds.

MINT

Investors bought HDFC ahead of CEO exit news

Ram Sahgal

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MUMBAI

Foreign and Indian investors are expected to take the leadership transition at HDFC Bank Ltd in stride, with the lender's American Depositary Receipt (ADR) rising sharply ahead of the disclosure and domestic shares recovering from a 52-week low on Friday.

HDFC Bank's ADR rose 2.76% to \$23.08 apiece on Friday, according to financial news website *MarketWatch*, a day before the lender informed stock exchanges that managing director and chief executive Sashidhar Jagdishan would step down when his second term ends on 26 October.

An ADR allows global investors to invest in a foreign company without buying its stock in the home country. A US bank purchases the company's shares in, say, India, and issues receipts against those shares to foreign investors on the New York Stock Exchange.

The domestic stock also recovered from a 52-week low of ₹707 on Friday, settling 1.3% higher at ₹720.30. About half of the gain came during the closing auction session, which is typically dominated by passive funds. Analysts expect the stock to rise further on Monday as domestic shares catch up with Friday's ADR gains.

"The fact that the ADR

and the share on the domestic market rose a day ahead of the disclosure indicates that the Street anticipated the news," said Ambareesh Baliga, an independent market analyst.

A mutual fund executive, on condition of anonymity, said the absence of a reappointment application suggested that Jagdishan's exit was imminent.

"Normally, the application for reappointment of an MD and CEO has to be submitted to RBI six months before the incumbent's term ends. In Jagdishan's case that didn't happen, implying that his exit was imminent," the executive said.

Interestingly, before the

The stock recovered from a 52-week low of ₹707 on Friday, settling 1.3% higher at ₹720.30

ADR closed on Friday, Indian call option sellers reduced open interest at the ₹720 strike call by 4%, driving up its price by 16% to ₹17.1.

share. One contract comprises 650 shares. "A call seller is bearish and the decision to square off shorts is in anticipation of a likely rally in the underlying share," said S.K. Joshi, consultant at Khambatta Securities.

The leadership change comes as HDFC Bank has become a favourite of domestic mutual funds.

Mutual fund holdings in the bank rose to 30.62% in June from 25.61% a year ago, while FPI holdings fell to 41.83% from 48.84%.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

AEL's valuation could limit gains

Manish Joshi

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Shares of Adani Enterprises (AEL) have gained 41% so far in 2026 to ₹3,169 apiece. Yet, further gains may be harder to justify on the valuation front.

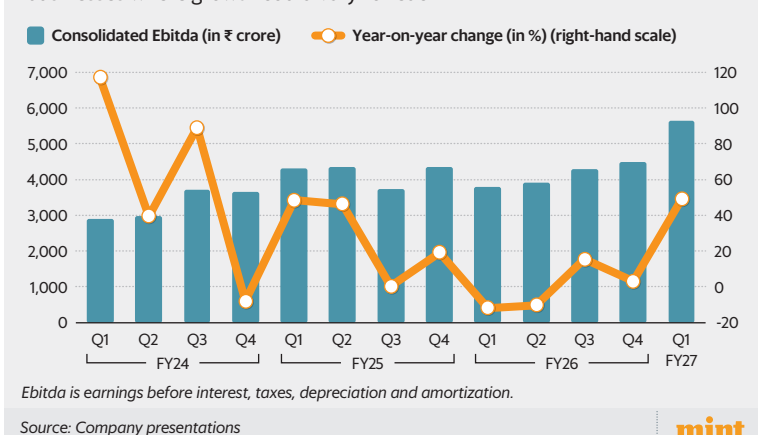
Last week, Motilal Oswal Financial Services initiated coverage on AEL with a sum-of-the-parts (SoTP)-based target price of ₹3,880, implying 22% upside from the current price. A couple of months ago, Morgan Stanley also initiated coverage with a target price of ₹3,638. *Bloomberg* consensus is about 20% above the current stock price.

The catch is that both brokerages are already assigning rich valuations to AEL's key businesses.

Motilal, for instance, values Adani Airport Holdings (AAHL), which accounts for 48% of its SoTP, at 35x enterprise value to Ebitda (EV/Ebitda) based on September 2028 estimates. That is more than double the 15x multiple assigned to GMR Airports based on FY29 estimates. Similarly, Motilal values Adani New Industries (ANIL), AEL's new-energy business and 19% of its SoTP, at 20x EV/Ebitda, a substan-

Divergence exemplified

Adani Enterprises' Ebitda growth can be lumpy due to the mix of underlying businesses where growth could vary for each.



tial premium to 8x for Waaree Energies, a solar equipment maker, and 12x for Suzlon Energy, a wind equipment maker.

AdaniConnex, the data-centre business that contributes 13% of SoTP, is valued at 30x EV/Ebitda based on September 2028 estimates, versus 14-18x for large global peers.

That leaves little room for further

valuation multiple expansion. Moreover, all of AEL's businesses are currently unlisted, meaning there is no holding company discount factored into the valuation. But AEL plans to list its key businesses between 2027 and 2031, starting with AAHL. Brokerages could therefore introduce a holding-company discount once these businesses begin to be spun out, as has hap-

pened with Reliance Industries (RIL), whose telecom business is expected to be listed soon.

Motilal has started factoring in a 25% holding-company discount for Jio Platforms (telecom vertical) in RIL's SoTP valuation following the June-quarter results.

For AEL's valuation to expand, earnings growth will need to do more of the work.

For AAHL, one potential growth lever is non-aero revenue, which includes shopping, food and beverage sales and advertising, among others. Non-aero revenue per passenger is far below global peers, offering large scope for monetization.

Meanwhile, aero revenue comprising landing, parking and user fees is determined for by keeping 14-15% internal rate of return (IRR) on regulatory-asset-base for a five-year period, ensuring stable cash flows.

ANIL is India's leading integrated renewable-energy equipment maker. In solar, it spans the value chain from polysilicon to solar panels and is target-

ing 10GW of capacity by FY27, up from 4GW currently. Its wind-turbine capacity is expected to reach 4GW by FY27 from 2.25GW now.

It has also commissioned India's first off-grid 5MW green-hydrogen pilot plant. If green hydrogen commercialization gains momentum, it could materially boost ANIL's earnings and give it a first-mover advantage.

AEL owns 50% of AdaniConnex, a joint venture with EdgeConnex, with a current operating capacity of 65MW across four data centres. The plan is to ramp up capacity to 3,000MW by 2030, potentially requiring about ₹2 trillion of capex.

Yes, AEL is a strong play on India's infrastructure-growth story. But the breadth of its portfolio also brings execution risks, particularly in newer businesses such as copper smelting. It already has six business verticals.

For investors seeking a focused play on a particular segment, especially airports, waiting for the separate listings of these businesses may therefore make more sense.

HIGH HOPES

BROKERAGES have assigned rich valuations to Adani Enterprises' key businesses

FOR AEL's valuation to expand, earnings growth will need to do more of the work

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

HDFC may turn to Plan B with just two months to find its next chief

FROM PAGE 1

made progress in technology, risk management, among other areas, the person said. Jagdishan also told the board that recent issues were behind them, the person added.

"This is the season of early resignations in the corporate and financial services world," said Abizer Diwanji, founder of strategic advisory provider Neostat Advisors.

Diwanji was referring to the recent decisions by Tata Sons chairman Natarajan Chandrasekaran and Kotak Mahindra Bank chief executive Ashok Vaswani to also not seek reappointment earlier this month.

"For HDFC, this does not end the uncertainty but is perhaps the beginning, at least till a full-time CEO is not appointed," said Diwanji. He said, given that there are only two months to go, the board is likely to appoint an interim CEO and start the search process for a full-time executive. "The bank has been in focus of late for a lot of things, and I hope a new chief can steer it out of the crisis."

Interestingly, Jagdishan seems to have changed his mind

on offering himself for another term. In March, in an interview to *Mint*, he had said he was willing to take on another term.

"Am I a willing candidate? Yes. I do not want to comment prematurely on the process, because it is the prerogative of the board and the regulator to provide the necessary approvals, but I am committing that I am willing," he had said.

According to some people aware of the development, Jagdishan had got indications that the board was not keen on his reappointment or that he could get a truncated term, and his current term was set to end in just two months' time. According to the second person aware of internal discussions, Jagdishan decided not to offer himself for reappointment because he did not want the ignominy of a shorter term, or worse, a rejection by RBI.

"Nobody clearly knows what RBI thinks on such issues and the central bank's stance is not easy to gauge," the person said.

The bank, however, rejected these reasons for his sudden announcement. "The reasons cited by you for Mr Jagdishan not seeking a new term are



Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision to not seek a new term as CEO when his tenure ends in Oct has suddenly put HDFC in transition mode. MINT

totally false and inaccurate," a spokesperson for HDFC Bank said in response to emailed queries.

Widely expected to be the interim CEO, the 60-year-old Bharucha has spent 31 years at the bank and took on the role of deputy managing director in April 2023.

A commerce graduate from Sydenham College of Commerce and Economics, University of Mumbai, Bharucha has been at the bank since its inception.

Experts said Bharucha comes with a tenure constraint for the

bank to consider him for the top job. RBI rules cap the total time an executive can serve as a whole-time director, including as managing director and chief executive, at 15 years. Since Bharucha joined HDFC Bank's board in 2014, that would leave him only until 2029, giving him a relatively short runway as a full-time chief executive.

"Internally, deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha can be recommended for managing director position—though (he) could get a shorter term due to RBI's rule of whole-time director max term of 15 years,"

said Anand Dama, executive director, head of banking and financial services research at Nuvama Institutional Equities.

This, said Dama, is an easy, faster and pragmatic solution, which will provide the bank time to groom someone internally or externally, and lead to minimal business disruption.

Jagdishan's slot is not the only top position the bank needs to fill.

Proxy advisory firm Institutional Investor Advisory Services India Ltd (IIAS) said in a note on Sunday that HDFC Bank's leadership challenge is further complicated by other impending vacancies across the executive suite and the board.

"V.S. Rangan, described as a 'safe pair of hands', who moved from HDFC Ltd to the bank, has his term ending in November 2026," it said, adding that the coming months will be defining for the top lender.

"Although it has long been viewed as one of India's best-managed financial institutions, the events of 2026 have exposed weaknesses in its governance framework. Rebuilding investor confidence will take more than assurances that the

financial impact was immaterial," the proxy advisory firm said.

HDFC Bank, once seen as the darling of the equity markets, has lost quite a bit of its appeal as against its peers. The numbers are telling.

Since Jagdishan joined and till the end of Friday, 28 August, the bank's stock has returned 27.72%, as against 266.67% for rival ICICI Bank. Its valuation has also weakened over time, down from a price-to-book value of 3.2 times when Jagdishan took over in 2020, to 1.8 times now, while ICICI Bank's ratio improved from 1.8 to 2.7 at present.

During Jagdishan's tenure, the bank's loanbook tripled to ₹30.6 trillion, while deposits expanded 2.6 times to ₹31.7 trillion as on 30 June.

The asset side expanded faster owing to the 2023 merger, where it took into its fold parent HDFC Ltd, while the deposits did not grow in tandem since the mortgage lender did not have a large deposit book. Over the same period, ICICI Bank's loan book has grown 2.5 times and deposits expanded 2.2 times.

'A modest interest rate hike need not derail India's growth story'

Ram Sahgal

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MUMBAI

Elevated crude prices following the West Asia war could feed into broader inflation expectations and force the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to intervene. However, monetary policy is more effective at moderating demand-side excesses than at addressing external supply constraints. Given this, a calibrated rate hike won't hurt, but prolonged tightening could impact rate sensitive



INTERVIEW

structural drivers. From here, earnings delivery rather than further valuation expansion will increasingly determine market returns.

Globally, rising interest rates in the US and Japan could spook financial markets amid uncertainty in crude. Is that a challenge?

Sustained high global yields and crude would certainly challenge India through inflation, the current account, the rupee and capital flows. However, much of the current

quarters. More importantly, after several quarters of downgrades, FY27 estimates have broadly stabilized, and FY28 has seen upgrades in several sectors. Financials, metals and domestic investment-linked sectors contributed to the improvement.

India's macro and earnings outlook remains constructive, subject to global macro and geopolitical conditions not deteriorating materially. Domestic consumption, infrastructure and private investment, financialization and formalization remain strong

structural drivers. From here, earnings delivery rather than further valuation expansion will increasingly determine market returns.

Globally, rising interest rates in the US and Japan could spook financial markets amid uncertainty in crude. Is that a challenge?

Sustained high global yields and crude would certainly challenge India through inflation, the current account, the rupee and capital flows. However, much of the current

crude pressure is geopolitical and linked to Iran and the Strait of Hormuz. If there is a durable settlement and normalization of traffic, crude could correct sharply, simultaneously reducing inflation, yields and rate-hike expectations. India would be a major beneficiary.

India also has stronger buffers today—large reserves, a well-capitalized financial system and much deeper domestic institutional participation. We should distinguish short-term volatility from any fundamental derailment of India's growth story.

There is a school of thought that believes in an AI bubble, which could result in a revival of foreign investor flows to India...

There is certainly a risk of excesses in parts of the global AI trade. (South) Korea and Taiwan have increasingly become proxies for the semiconductor and memory cycle, making emerging-market weights and flows more cyclical. As substantial new capacity comes on stream, if the AI hardware cycle corrects, India's relative attractiveness within emerging markets could improve,



attracting flows.

More importantly, India's AI opportunity is not limited to manufacturing GPUs (graphics processing units). We can become one of the world's largest users of AI across financial services, healthcare, manufacturing, education and government. Capabilities are also developing in high-tech and defence manufacturing, AI models, semiconductors, data centres and electronics. The perception that India is outside the AI trade should progressively fade.

The minutes of the RBI meeting indicate we could be entering a rate-hike cycle, maybe as early as October. How could this impact markets?

I would not assume an October hike is inevitable. RBI is rightly vigilant, but much of the current inflation impulse is supply-driven. Monetary policy is better at moderating excess demand than resolving an external supply constraint.

If crude remains elevated and feeds into broader inflation expectations, RBI may need to

act. But if geopolitics improves and crude normalizes, inflation, global yields and tightening probabilities could decline quickly. Strong FCNR(B) inflows also provide an external buffer. A modest hike need not derail growth, but a prolonged tightening cycle would affect leveraged and rate-sensitive businesses and raise lenders' funding costs.

On FCNR(B), how would this impact the rupee and buttress against potential FPI outflows?

The exceptionally strong FCNR(B) response provides an important near-term

buffer for the rupee and greater capacity to manage volatility from FPI outflows. But we should distinguish borrowed reserves from permanent capital: these deposits ultimately carry repayment obligations.

India remains a capital-hungry economy with enormous investment opportunities. We should attract patient, long-du-

ration global savings through a stable, predictable and globally competitive regulatory and tax framework. Sustained foreign inflows support the currency, currency stability improves investor confidence, and that can attract further capital—a powerful virtuous cycle.

Climate change is a big problem that could have economic impact globally. What is your view on its impact on the global economy in general and India in particular?

Climate change is increasingly an economic and financial issue. Rising tempera-

tures and extreme weather can affect agricultural yields, labour productivity, food inflation and infrastructure. India is particularly exposed because of our large agricultural population, water stress, coastline and rapidly growing cities.

But the energy transition is also a major opportunity. Renewable power, transmis-

sion, storage, electric mobility, green hydrogen and climate-resilient infrastructure will require enormous investment. India can build globally competitive manufacturing capabilities across this ecosystem. Capital goods, power equipment and renewable-energy supply chains can be important beneficiaries, creating investment, innovation and employment.

Non-banks have gone through significant regulatory tightening. IIFL Finance itself faced an RBI embargo on its gold loan business in 2024. What was the learning?

We took the RBI action seriously and used it to examine not merely the specific observations but also our entire operating architecture. We have strengthened governance, risk management, compliance, internal audit, technology, Board and management oversight, systems and accountability. In gold loans, processes around valuation, LTV monitoring, auctions, customer communication, charges and documentation have been strengthened.



TAFE bets on a fifth plant

Mother-daughter duo Mallika Srinivasan & Lakshmi Venu to invest ₹1,250 cr in first greenfield plant in 29 years.

T. Surendar, Varun Sood & Satish John

MUMBAI

After three decades, India's second-largest tractor maker is building capacity again. Tractors and Farm Equipment Ltd will set up its fifth plant in a north Indian state, its first greenfield in 29 years, as it doubles down on exports after a breakout year, with revenue up 25% to ₹16,000 crore. "We will be setting up a north India facility with about 60,000 tractors capacity, with the location still being decided," said Mallika Srinivasan, chairperson and managing director of TAFE.

The mother and daughter are not just looking at Indian farmers. "We're confident of growing internationally, and that's why we're putting in capacity. Capacity is now going to come up fast, because it's giving us very good confidence in terms of both domestic and export demand," Mallika added.

TAFE, which has a production capacity of 260,000 tractors across its four manufacturing plants, expects its fifth manufacturing facility to come up within 18 months, and will spend up to ₹1,250 crore, according to an executive. The four existing facilities include its flagship plant in Chennai (set up in 1961), sites in Doddaballapur near Bengaluru (1981) and Kaladipatti near Madurai (1997), and the Bhopal plant added through its acquisition of Eicher's tractor business in 2005.

Rajasthan is a key manufacturing hub for the group. Through its subsidiary TAFE Motors, the company has partnered with German engine maker DEUTZ AG to produce up to 30,000 diesel and internal combustion engines annually at its Alwar plant. Having sold 214,000 tractors last year, TAFE expects the new facility to further bolster its market footprint across north India.



TAFE vice chair Lakshmi Venu (left) with Mallika Srinivasan, chairperson and managing director of the company.

The fresh capacity push follows a stellar financial performance for the company over the past year. "Certainly, revenue saw a boost, and last year was one of our best years," said Mallika. "We had 24.8% growth domestically. We sold about 214,000 tractors. That took the revenue closer

both mother and daughter spoke with *Mint* in a rare media interview on Friday. "One, the monsoon was good last year. The second is the government's move on the GST rate for the industry, which gave it a good fillip. Some state governments also rolled out farmer-friendly actions. So, with that change

onstrate that she can drive a straight furrow in a 65-HP tractor—championing a vision where the future Indian farmer can just as easily be a woman managing the land on her own terms.

The company expects revenue to grow 10% this fiscal year. "The fears of El Niño causing a very serious issue, I think those have died down. June was the driest we saw. But it didn't look as bad. With July and August rains actually catching up, we're doing pretty well. So overall, if you ask me today, maybe a bit difficult to call, but with a slight softening of the growth rate because of the high base, buoyed by the structural parameters that are in favour, I think we could end the year (FY27) somewhere around 10%," said Mallika.

TAFE—which held an 18% market share in the first nine months of FY26, behind M&M's 44%—has gained ground in the 41-50 HP tractor segment, Crisil wrote in a note dated 2 February. From less than a 50% share of this most popular power segment in FY20, TAFE's share expanded to 63% by the end of FY25, Crisil noted. New Delhi's decision to reduce GST from 12% to 5% in September last year made these compact-built tractors more attractive for farming, haulage, and construction.

This growth momentum comes despite broader industry projections indicating a near-term moderation in demand. Rating agency Crisil wrote in a note dated 18 March that tractor sales growth is projected to slow to 0-2% this year to 1.2 million units, due to "normalisation of domestic demand after the high base of this fiscal and the emerging El Niño weather pattern".

"Rural sentiment remains strong: Tractor demand remained healthy, supported by higher MSP (minimum support price), kharif sowing progression and improving monsoon deficit," analysts at BOB Capital Market, the investment banking and financial services arm of Bank of Baroda, wrote in

a note dated 19 August.

For now, Mahindra and Mahindra remains the largest player, having sold 534,507 units last year. In February, M&M also announced plans to set up an auto and tractor manufacturing facility in Nagpur with an investment of ₹15,000 crore over 10 years.

"Today, India is one of the largest producers of tractors," said Mallika. "While it's one of the most competitive, there is a certain camaraderie in building opportunities for the industry as a whole. I think some of us also go back a little bit with some personal relationships that have been there among promoters, among promoter families, and also the individual culture of the organisations," she added.

Beyond operational expansion, TAFE has also undergone a major corporate restructuring. At the privately held TAFE, another major development was the cash purchase of a 20% stake held by AGCO—a US-based manufacturer of brands such as Massey Ferguson and Fendt—for about \$260 million (₹2,300 crore). The deal makes TAFE a wholly owned subsidiary of the Chennai-based Amalgamations Group.

"We have had a long and successful partnership with AGCO; it has lasted for 65 years, and I believe this entire arrangement is a win-win situation. We are still [AGCO's] largest single shareholder," said Mallika. "That is the main reason for the transaction—you can't deal with it bit by bit; you have to consider the whole thing as a single package. That is all I would like to add about it." On Friday, the 16.3% stake held by Mallika and TAFE in AGCO was worth \$1.3 billion. Financial statements of TAFE, founded by Mallika's grandfather, S. Anantharamakrishnan, are not filed with the ministry of corporate affairs, so its profitability is unknown. Currently debt-free, the company has no plans to raise capital through an initial public offering.

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Jagdishan, CEO who loves thinking and *thayir sadam*

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Sashidhar Jagdishan joined HDFC Bank as a manager in the finance department in 1996.

For over three decades, Sashidhar Jagdishan was the HDFC Bank insider who rose through the ranks to inherit its most coveted seat. He joined the bank in 1996, spent years running its finance function, and eventually became the man chosen to follow the formidable first chief executive Aditya Puri. Now, six years after taking charge, 'Sashi', as colleagues know him (and as some of the bank's older annual reports call him) is preparing to leave the corner office at a time when questions around governance have become as important to the bank's future growth.

A Mumbaikar, Jagdishan was born and brought up in the bustling bylanes of Matunga, and continues to live in the city with his wife and son. Away from the numbers and balance sheets, his preferred way of unwinding is in the kitchen, as he enjoys cooking and experimenting with food, although the humble *'thayir sadam'* (curd rice) remains a favourite. Every weekend, he takes his turn cooking for family and friends, according to information on the bank's website.

An executive who knows him for a long time, said, above all, Jagdishan is a good human being. "You have to look at Sashi the individual as well. He does not want to deal with the daily scrutiny, especially on social media, anymore," the executive said. "He has had a long career, and thought it was

Governance concerns have grown as the CEO prepares to quit, putting the bank's leadership under greater scrutiny

the apt time to step down." s His interests outside banking are distinctly rooted in the arts and routine. He listens to music, particularly Carnatic, reads when he finds the time, and counts cycling as his sport of choice. It is a portrait rather different from the one suggested by his public persona: a long-serving finance executive, who few expected to take the top job in 2020, let alone step down before a third term.

Another HDFC Bank executive, who worked with Jagdishan when he still was the chief financial

officer, the primary difference between him and Puri is his willingness to listen to people's views. "Puri used to say, you leave the thinking to me and just focus on the execution. Jagdishan, on the other hand, would listen to what people had to say," he said. The former executive said it was this facet that probably went against him.

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Ather Energy takes on TVS and Bajaj with new designs

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Ather Energy Ltd is borrowing a page from legacy two-wheeler makers, adopting time-tested designs and pairing them with its tech features to mount its most direct assault yet on market leaders TVS Motor Co. and Bajaj Auto Ltd.

After establishing its brand with sleek, performance-oriented models, the Bengaluru-based electric vehicle maker is shifting toward practical, mainstream design elements, such as handlebar-mounted headlights, centre stands, and longer seating, to appeal to everyday commuters, Ather chief executive Tarun Mehta told *Mint*. The shift aims to replicate the mass adoption achieved decades ago by scooters like the Honda Activa.

Despite an 82% surge in sales during fiscal year 2026 (FY26) that elevated Ather to India's third-largest electric two-wheeler manufacturer, the company still faces stiff competition. Its entry-level

vehicles remain roughly 30% more expensive than legacy petrol alternatives, and competitors TVS and Bajaj continue to hold larger market shares.

Mehta said the company will not sacrifice brand equity or chase volume purely for market dominance as it enters the competitive ₹1-1.2 lakh price bracket. Instead, Ather is focusing on scaling, expanding annual manufacturing capacity to 920,000 units by late 2027 to capture long-term demand.

The brand started with a performance-focused 450 scooter range to establish Ather as a technology-led EV brand, with Mehta saying the company first needed to build something "magical" and dif-



Ather Energy co-founders Swapnil Jain (left) and Tarun Mehta with the new Konarc electric scooter.

ferentiated before adapting its technology for a wider audience.

When asked whether the company is chasing the familiarity legacy brands built over the past few decades with scooters, Mehta said it has to strike a balance.

"It's a very delicate balance. If all you do is solve for expectations, you end up with the boring non-aspirational scooter. If all you do is build the magic, then you're not able to solve for a large chunk of the customers," Mehta said.

The company's new product remains 30% pricier than the entry-level variant of an Activa

"The right sequence that we believe will work is to first figure out something magical. As a new brand, you need something at your core where you're truly differentiated," he

added. Some of the traditional elements it has tried to include in its latest offering, Konarc, are a centre stand, a headlight in the handlebars, and longer seats, giving the product a more traditional scooter look. These elements have been added, along with a new set of features across braking, charging, and suspension.

The task of recreating what legacy companies were able to do remains a tall one, owing to the pricier scooters. For instance, the entry variant of

Ather's new product remains 30% pricier than the entry-level variant of an Activa.

Founded in 2013, Ather began selling electric scooters in 2018 with its 450 range and later expanded into a more family-focused scooter, the Rizta, in 2024, which helped it scale its sales and take on market leaders TVS, Bajaj, and Ola Electric.

It ended FY26 as the third-largest EV two-wheeler maker, ahead of Ola Electric and Hero Motocorp, with sales jumping 82% to 239,178, giving it a 17% market share, according to data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Association (Fada).

As sales scaled, its shares have jumped by 438% over the past year since it listed in May 2025.

"The challenge for Ather is not the adoption of new elements or features, but the adoption of electric as a reliable and friendly alternative to the legacy scooter, easy to operate across all age bands and genders," Avik Chattopadhyay, founder, Indian School for Design of Automobiles, XLRI Delhi-NCR, said.

While the company scales, it still lags behind TVS and Bajaj, which ended FY26 with 24% and 21% market share, a gap it could look to close with new mass-market products built on the EL platform.

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Tata Motors sees strong EV demand: MD & CEO

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Tata Motors Ltd expects demand for its electric commercial vehicles (CVs) to remain strong and continue to grow with a strong order book in place across segments, according to its managing director (MD) and chief executive officer (CEO) Girish Wagh.

The company also expects supply chain bottleneck regarding cells imported from China that has impacted its Intra EV (Electric vehicle), to be resolved completely by the end of the ongoing quarter, he told analysts.

"On EVs, the demand outlook is quite positive," he said. In the first quarter of the fiscal year, on the electric commercial vehicles front, Tata Motors had over 3,400 vehicle orders across segments, building on the momentum it saw in the second half of last year.

In addition to that, Wagh said, "As a part of PM-eBus Sewa, there are a few more newer tenders which are also on the way. We are quite positive on that." He pointed out that the electric small commercial vehicles (SCV) pickup, which is completely in the retail market, is doing very well. "The TCO (total cost of ownership) parity of Intra, Ace Pro has become very attractive in comparison to their ICE (internal combustion engine) 'brothers'. Therefore from that perspective, the demand will remain strong and will continue to grow," Wagh noted.

Commenting on Tata Motors' capacity of supplying electric EVs, particularly 'Intra EV', he said, "In-house capacity is not a challenge at all. Wagh, however, added, "We have placed higher set of orders already around two months back.

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Govt mulls sops for electric bus, truck charging infra

The move aims to reduce the high upfront cost of buying and running commercial vehicles

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Government may offer interest subvention for charging infrastructure alongside its proposed financing scheme for electric buses and trucks, as operators face a second major upfront cost beyond buying the pricier vehicles, said two people in the know, on the condition of anonymity.

The plan, being discussed since early 2026, was pegged at ₹9,852 crore as of May to provide interest subvention and credit guarantees for the rollout of 50,000 e-buses and 50,000 e-trucks over five years. It aims to reduce the high upfront cost of these vehicles, with each costing at least twice as much as its diesel counterpart, according to an official document reviewed by *Mint*. The May proposal did not include support for charging infrastructure.

The ministry is now considering adding incentives for charging infrastructure, as operators either have to buy chargers for their depots or tie up with charge point operators to keep vehicles running, the people said.

"With e-bus and e-truck demand set to rise, the demand for fast chargers will also increase, and the ministry is considering providing some incentives for charging infrastructure under the new e-bus and e-truck financing scheme," said one of the people cited above, a senior government official.

Queries emailed to the heavy industries ministry on 27 August seeking comment remained unanswered.

The need for high-powered chargers is getting more pressing as electric commercial-vehicle sales grow. India, world's third-largest e-bus market,



The proposed scheme was being discussed since early 2026.

PTI

according to the International Energy Agency, saw e-bus sales rise 81% to 3,644 units in FY24. Sales then fell 6% to 3,314 units in FY25 before rebounding 37% to 5,356 units in FY26, according to the government's Vahan registry.

The low uptake was due to a shortage of heavy electric trucks that complied with the scheme's localization norm, as well as challenges in procuring scrapping certificates for older diesel trucks that would be replaced with electric

as per data compiled by state-run Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd (BHEL), the nodal agency for EV charging subsidies under PM E-Drive. But the network has very limited high-capacity charging infrastructure: only 534, or 0.7%, have a capacity of 121-240 kilowatts, while just 9, or 0.01%, have a capacity above 240kW, according to the dashboard.

High-capacity chargers of over 120kW are crucial for rapid charging of e-buses and trucks, as slower ones will raise the downtime of these expensive assets, said the second person.

The proposed charging support would build on the ₹2,000 crore charging-infrastructure subsidy under PM E-Drive, launched in 2024. Under the scheme, the heavy industries ministry planned to support installation of 72,000 chargers across vehicle segments through the subsidy, with funds to be channelled via state agencies.

However, a Rajya Sabha parliamentary panel report of August said the ministry had sanctioned ₹689 crore in subsidies for setting up 6,562 chargers.

The proposed bundled financing support, would, therefore seek to address both sides of the commercial-EV equation: the high upfront cost of the vehicle and the capital required to build the charging infrastructure needed to operate it.

"It is important to understand that investments made for setting up chargers for e-buses and e-trucks are large and capex-heavy. So, bundled benefits—charging infra benefits stitched together with vehicle procurement ones—can assist the EV ecosystem in faster growth and adoption," said Sharif Qamar, associate director of transport and urban governance at The Energy and Resources Institute (Teri).

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India's consumer-protection plan has an AI blind spot

FROM PAGE 1

that a free service rendered in an establishment where others pay is still a 'service'. This will cover freemium services," said Anupam Shukla, partner at law firm Pioneer Legal.

Another challenge is determining who bears liability. Under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, consumers can seek compensation for harm caused by defective products or services, with liability potentially resting on manufacturers, sellers and service providers. The question, therefore, is if this framework adequately covers AI-related harm, given the number of entities involved in developing and deploying AI systems.

Experts say determining who is responsible can be complicated since an AI system can involve several players, from developers and designers to companies that deploy the technology.

"Where the supply itself is an AI-enabled use case such as an application, the liability could be affixed to developers, designers, and deployers, depending on where causation arose, where assessment is likely to move beyond the Consumer Protection Act to cover assessment around responsible AI principles, data protection, IP, and other relevant laws," said Arya Tripathy, partner at law firm Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

However, the question becomes more complicated when AI is used only as part of another product or service. In such cases, holding the AI provider liable could require consumers to meet a higher bur-



The definition of 'service' in the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, excludes services rendered entirely free of charge. REUTERS

den of proof, Tripathy added.

"In terms of proportionately distributing liability, the final service provider deploying the AI system, which faces the consumer, may be held principally liable, although the definition of a product under the Consumer Protection Act leaves room for upstream liability across the AI lifecycle," the authors of a paper titled *AI and Consumer Rights in India*, published by the Centre for Responsible AI at IIT Madras, told *Mint*.

The ambiguity extends to how AI systems themselves fit within the Act. The Consumer Protection Act defines a "product" broadly, but its statutory framework is principally structured around goods, products and services in their conventional forms.

"This creates questions regarding the treatment of software and AI systems, particularly because the Act does not expressly define software or AI as a distinct category of product. While certain forms of software may potentially fall within the concepts of 'goods'

or 'product', particularly where software is supplied as a standalone or embedded product, software may also form part of, or be delivered through, a 'service' arrangement," said Mukhija.

Another concern is dark patterns. Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) norms cover 13 practices that can undermine consumer choice but experts say they may not fully address AI-driven manipulation. Like, an AI agent that flatters and steers users to a product may not fit existing categories such as "confirm shaming".

"Since the existing guidelines may not capture AI-driven manipulation, the CCPA must eventually recognize such practices," said Abhivardhan, founder of Indic Pacific, a technology law consultancy and president of ISAIL.IN, an AI standards community.

India may not need a new regime, it should strengthen the current framework with clear allocation of AI liability, transparency and mechanisms to address challenges of AI-related claims, said Mukhija. The EU offers useful lessons.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

The ambiguity extends to how artificial intelligence systems themselves fit within the Act

INFRASTRUCTURE GAP

THE ₹9,852 crore scheme aims to support 50,000 e-buses and 50,000 e-trucks over 5 years

THE May proposal did not include support for charging infrastructure

THE ministry is now considering adding incentives for charging infrastructure

NEED for high-powered charging infra is rising as electric commercial-vehicle sales grow

Govt faces fert subsidy heat even as urea prices ease

FROM PAGE 1

government has already spent ₹99,128 crore or nearly 56% of its annual fertilizer subsidy in the first four and a half months (1 April-19 August) of FY27.

"A subsidy of ₹77,872 crore has been incurred towards imports and domestic production of urea, while ₹21,256 crore has been so far provided for subsidies for imports as well as domestic production of other nutrient-based fertilizers such DAP, MOP and NPKs," a government official aware of the expenditure said.

Cheaper urea offers some relief, however. In June, a global urea tender floated by state-run National Fertilisers Ltd (NFL) received import bids of \$445-449 per tonne, a sharp decline from \$935-959 in May, as supply fears eased and China raised export. It remains to be seen if the trend persists through the season.

However, soaring sulphur and ammonia, key inputs in fertilizer making, could raise output cost for phosphatic and complex fertilizers. Ammonia prices rose 58% year-on-year to \$681 a tonne, while sulphur jumped 275% to \$1,050. Ammonia and sulphur are used by manufacturers IFFCO, Kribhco, Gujarat State Fertilizers and Chemicals, Coromandel International.

Queries emailed to the fertilizer department on 28 August remained unanswered. A sustained weakness in urea prices could lead to lower import costs and part-offset the pressure arising from higher DAP, MOP and phosphatic fertilizer prices.

For the government, this means that the impact on its fertilizer bill will depend on the consumption pattern, import requirement and the global price trend in the coming months.

Tata Trusts seeks nod to break Tata Sons chair selection jam

FROM PAGE 1

Tata Trusts could not jointly nominate a member to attend the meeting, resulting in the AGM being adjourned for lack of quorum, a first in its history.

Last week, the Registrar of Companies granted Tata Sons a three-month extension to hold its AGM.

Call and text messages to charity commissioner Amogh Kaloti seeking comment went unanswered. An email sent to Tata Trusts seeking comment also went unanswered.

The five-member SRTT board is led by Noel, Mumbai-based lawyer Darius Khambata, Pune-based businessman-philanthropist Jehangir H.C. Jehangir, and Ratan Tata's younger brother, Jimmy Naval Tata. Retired defence secretary Vijay Singh, who stepped down from the SRTT board earlier this month, and TVS chairman emeritus Venu Srinivasan, a member of the trust, have complained to the charity



N. Chandrasekaran had said he wouldn't seek a third term. PTI

commissioner about the trust's board composition.

Tata Trusts, along with other smaller trusts, including SDTT and SRTT, own 65.9% of Tata Sons.

Under Tata Sons' articles of association, a five-member selection committee will appoint the next chairman. SDTT and SRTT jointly nominate three members. The Tata Sons board nominates one, and Tata Sons selects one independent member from outside the Group. SDTT and SRTT choose the selection

committee chairman from among their three nominees.

"One option available for the Tata Trusts to fast-track this entire process is to file a writ petition before the Bombay High Court asking to intervene and direct the charity commissioner to allow them to go ahead with the setting up of a selection committee," said senior Supreme Court lawyer H.P. Ranina.

However, Tata executives maintain that the question of whether three of the five members of SRTT, as permanent trustees, are in breach of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Rules, which stipulate that no more than a fourth of trustees can be lifetime members, could get them drawn into a long legal wrangle.

"We don't want to take this matter to the court because there is a view that it could delay things, and we remain hopeful that the charity commissioner will consider our request," said the executive cited above.

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CEO exit may lift HDFC Street sentiment

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Sashidhar Jagdishan's exit from HDFC Bank brings to an end a tenure marked by regulatory scrutiny, governance allegations and severe market underperformance, even as the bank's loans and deposits grew smartly. The move could revive investor confidence in HDFC Bank, industry observers said.

While his first term starting October 2020 was marked by the landmark merger with HDFC Ltd, the second term saw a slate of negative news, including alleged mis-selling of AT-1 bonds, preferential deposit pricing for a government company, and the abrupt exit of its chairman.

"It's in the interest of the organization. If an individual is impacting the stability of the organization, it's noble of the individual to step aside for the organization," said Abizer Divanji, Founder - NeoStrat Advisors LLP, adding that the only issue will be appointing an interim CEO. "It was a much bigger issue, and the



During Jagdishan's tenure, shares of HDFC Bank gained 27.7%, against 266.67% at rival ICICI Bank. BLOOMBERG

bank's valuation was getting impacted because of the sentiment. So, it's a fair strategy to protect the brand. It is inherently a good organization," Divanji said.

"Some noise will settle because there was uncertainty regarding his continuity," said Siddharth Goel, Director - APAC Financial institutions, Fitch Ratings.

"From an investor's point of view, they might see that something fresh is now there

because valuations have come down. With a new CEO coming in, along with the recently appointed chairman, the group can now pursue a more stable strategy for future growth rather than thinking about management concerns. That way the execution burden can ease," Goel added.

During Jagdishan's tenure, shares of HDFC Bank gained 27.7%, against 266.67% at rival ICICI Bank, even as its loan book tripled to

₹30.6 trillion and deposits expanded 2.6 times to ₹31.7 trillion. Valuation weakened—the price-to-book value fell from 3.2 times when Jagdishan took over in 2020, to 1.8 times now. In comparison, ICICI Bank's valuation improved from 1.8 to 2.7 times over this period.

Investors want to know not only whether specific issues have been resolved, but also what has fundamentally changed to reduce the likelihood of recurrence, proxy advisory firm Institutional Investor Advisory Services (IIAS) said in a note, adding the coming months will be "defining" for HDFC Bank.

"As the bank engages with the RBI on CEO succession, executive director appointments, and the induction of new independent directors, investors will see these choices as a test of the board's commitment to governance and long term value," the firm said, adding that investors will expect the new leadership to show that lessons have been learned from recent missteps.

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HDFCs price-to-book value fell from 3.2 times when Jagdishan took over to 1.8 times, while ICICI's gained

India's airport boom is losing steam as airlines run short of planes

FROM PAGE 1

financial distress and industry net losses are forecast to escalate to ₹360-380 Bn in FY 2027," GMR said.

IndiGo and Air India group, including the low-cost carrier Air India Express, which together account for more than 90% of India's domestic airline market, reported losses of over ₹22,000 crore and nearly ₹2,400 crore in FY26.

Privately held Akasa Air and SpiceJet—the two other major airlines—are yet to detail. "Ongoing restructuring and fleet reduction by budget carriers has resulted in lower domestic capacity utilization at airports," GMR said. "Supply-side constraints persisted: about 99 aircraft remained grounded across selected air-

lines at March-end."

The Noida International Airport said that as a new airport, it looks to maintain stable operations and expand connectivity in a phased manner. "We continue to work closely with our airline partners to grow the route network in line with airline plans and passenger demand. The long-term fundamentals of Delhi-NCR and Western Uttar Pradesh region remain strong, and our long-term outlook is unchanged," a spokesperson told *Mint*.

GMR Airports and BIAL did not respond to queries.

The impact is visible in GMR's traffic numbers. Its airports handled 121.6 million passengers in FY26, barely 1% higher than 120.6 million a year earlier. Cargo, however,



Bengaluru airport operator BIAL says the aviation sector's 'aftershocks' will likely spill over into FY27. ISTOCKPHOTO

was resilient, with volumes across GMR-operated airports rising to 1.33 million tonnes.

GMR's Indian airport portfolio has also grown. Besides its established operations at

Delhi, Hyderabad and Mopa, the group has added Nagpur and Bhogapuram to its portfolio. It is also evaluating the proposed privatization of 11 regional AAI airports and

potential airport development opportunities in Chennai, Kolkata and Pune.

Noida is an example of how airline constraints are playing out. Zurich Airport chief executive Lukas Brosi said in an investor call that the new airport's operations had started successfully, but the geopolitical environment had resulted in a "more gradual ramp-up than originally anticipated."

Zurich has also said Noida will put pressure on its near-term profitability. The airport is expected to make a negative contribution in 2026, with breakeven expected in 2027.

Fairfax-owned BIAL, in its

annual report for 2025-26 described the year as "amongst the most challenging years in recent history" for aviation and said the sector's "after-shocks will likely spill over into FY27". Yet Kempegowda International Airport handled 44.47 million passengers, up 6.2%, with international traffic up 23.9% to 7.23 million. Cargo grew about 6%, while

income rose 15% to ₹4,579 crore, and PAT increased more than 86% to ₹1,115 crore. Bengaluru shows that the underlying demand is intact, even as airline capacity increasingly determines how much of it airports capture.

For GMR, the response is to build businesses around the passenger rather than depend entirely on the passenger. GMR Aero Technic generated ₹676.9 crore in FY26 revenue, up 26%, while cargo, retail, food and beverage and airport-related real estate are becoming important parts of its platform. Diversification has supported its performance. Gross income rose 40% to ₹15,200.8 crore, and consolidated PAT was ₹472.4 crore, against a loss of ₹816.9 crore in FY25.

GMR remains confident that the current disruption does not alter the structural aviation opportunity, with the medium-term demand outlook remaining "firmly positive".

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



India eyes top telecom post; Pakistan signals its support

India has nominated Revathi Mannepalli for director of ITU's Radiocommunication Bureau

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More than six decades after an Indian held the International Telecommunication Union's (ITU) top elected post, New Delhi is once again hopeful of securing a key leadership position at the UN agency responsible for coordinating global telecommunications.

In 2025, the government nominated Revathi Mannepalli, joint wireless adviser at the department of telecommunications, as its candidate for director of the Radiocommunication Bureau (BR) at the ITU, one of the agency's five top leadership positions.

Mannepalli, also a member of the ITU Radio Regulations Board, will be contesting against two European candidates: Eric Fournier of France and Alexander Kuhn of Germany. In November, Doha, the capital of Qatar, will host the next Plenipotentiary Conference, the ITU's highest policy-making body, to elect the UN agency's leadership for a four-year term from 2027 to 2030. If elected, Mannepalli will become the first woman director and also the first person from the Asia, Australasia and Africa regions to be elected as director of the BR.

"We have a fair chance of winning this time," Mannepalli said in response to *Mint's* questions during a vote appeal address to the Commonwealth member countries at an event by the Commonwealth Telecommunications Organization (CTO) on 26 August.

"32 years back, the BR director position was created, but it never came to region 3 (Asia-Pacific). If you look at the diversity of the countries in region 3, we have island nations and landlocked countries. We have developing nations. I think this is the right time for it to



Revathi Mannepalli, joint wireless adviser, department of telecommunications.

come to region 3," Mannepalli said, adding there is plenty of opportunity.

The BR governs and regulates the international use of radio-frequency spectrum, covering mobile networks, satellite constellations and orbital slots,

nations—France and Germany—could split the vote and reduce Europe's chances of winning against India's candidate, according to a March report by online news platform *Geneva Solutions*. Analysts add that if one of the European

well as expertise in satellite communications and frequency management. Even Pakistan has expressed interest in backing Mannepalli for the position.

"We made it very clear, I gave a black and white answer, no grey answers. Dr Revathi is the best candidate for the job. Pakistan has no problem," Muhammad Amir Malik, member (international coordination) at the ministry of IT and telecommunication, Pakistan, said in response to *Mint's* questions at the CTO event.

"It is about collaboration among member states. If we are at this forum, India and Pakistan are partners, so they can be partners at every forum," Malik said, adding that Pakistan has no problem in supporting India for re-election to the ITU council seat. David Wills, group head, spectrum, at the UK's regulator Office of Communications, said, "I think everybody was happy to see, not just an Indian candidate, a female candidate as well... Other regions, from talking to them, look very positively on there being a candidate from India."

There is a lot that goes into ITU elections, and there are a lot of discussions with different regions to ensure there's regional balance, said Wills. "There are concerns that there are two European candidates. Whereas you might end up with a far more unified European vote, I think you may have some split," he said, adding that India has been really active in all the standards and is also recognized as becoming significantly more active at ITU-R (radiocommunication).

Ensuring a balanced approach to innovation, protection from harmful interference, and the sustainability of spectrum, as well as promoting consistent, transparent, and timely application of technology alongside the required regulations, are among Mannepalli's key priorities if elected.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

YouTube views get easier, but viewer retention gets harder

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YouTube is making views easier to count—and harder to take at face value. Its new view metric could push creators away from chasing volume and towards making fewer, more engaging pieces of content, as brands and platforms place greater value on whether audiences actually stay and watch.

Under the new guidelines, effective 24 August 2026, a YouTube view counts as soon as a video starts, even if the viewer immediately pauses or exits. Long-form videos previously informally needed around 30 seconds of watch time to count as a view. YouTube will now track continued viewing as an "engaged view", although it has not set a fixed threshold because content lengths vary; industry participants broadly see it as viewing beyond the first frame and initial few seconds.

The change applies globally across long-form videos, live streams, podcasts and Shorts, putting an emphasis on creators' ability to hold viewers' attention from the opening. "I think this change will push creators to look beyond the head-

Creators must now prioritize attention over volume and clicks, as watch time, retention gain importance

line view count and focus more on whether people are actually staying and engaging with the content. Metrics such as watch time, retention, engagement and audience quality will become more important when evaluating creators," said Neha Bhat, who creates travel, lifestyle and relationship-centric content.

A smaller creator with a highly engaged community can potentially deliver more value than a much larger but passive audience, she said. Her partner Thejas Bhat agreed, saying views are still important because they indicate reach, but they don't tell the complete story. Creators will have to optimize for attention, not just clicks, he pointed out.

YouTube said the change is aimed at creating a consistent standard for measuring views, capturing creators' exposure and influence across formats while making it easier to demonstrate their value to brand partners. For creators, the change removes some of the value of what Prafulla Kumar Jha, founder and chief executive of JEEV MEDIA, calls "hook arbitrage". If a view registers as soon as a video starts, the thumbnail and first two seconds are no longer the whole game, making retention more important.

Archisman Misra, founder and CEO of Studio Backdrops, said the rethink is whether anything a creator makes is worth a second visit—a harder skill that most creators never needed as content creation has surged in the past four years. The creators who will be fine, he said, are those who quietly

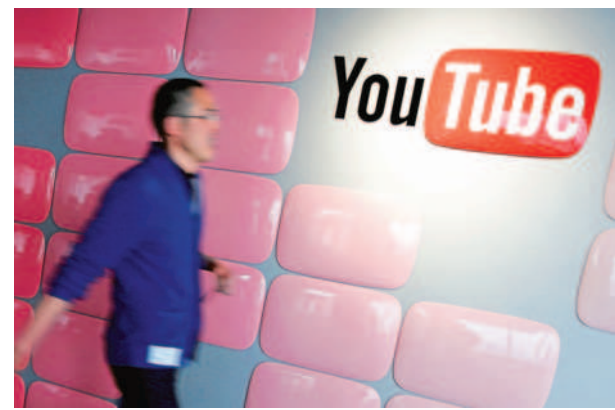
got good at the less visible parts of making content.

"Every shift points to YouTube becoming more deliberate about the value of attention and creators who consistently command it. The change in how public views are counted may make reach look larger, but also makes it more important to distinguish between distribution and genuine engagement," said Rajni Daswani, chief growth officer-people and business, SoCheers.

Harshit Arora, founder and CEO, Growster, said the move will prompt brands to look beyond follower counts and public views towards engaged views, watch time, retention, audience quality and, ultimately, business outcomes.

That matters especially for performance-oriented brands, which need to know not just how many people saw their content, but what those views achieved. As creators with engaged audiences become more valuable, platforms are competing harder for their talent. Netflix has been signing popular Indian YouTube creators such as Samay Raina and Bhuvan Bam to make original shows, while also bringing their existing YouTube content to its platform.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



YouTube now counts a view as soon as a video starts, while if one continues viewing it is tracked as an "engaged view". BLOOMBERG

We have localized ourselves to Indian sensibilities: Uniqlo

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MUMBAI

On 26 August, commerce minister Piyush Goyal said Japanese textile firms, including Uniqlo, will raise sourcing from India and invest more in to manufacture and export globally.

Uniqlo is expanding rapidly in India. The Japanese casual-wear brand has grown to 20 stores in seven years, posting revenue of ₹1,192.9 crore in 2024-25, up 45% from a year ago, according to market intelligence platform Tracxn. It has been consistently profitable in India, unlike other apparel retailers that have struggled to be profitable here. So, what is working?

Nidhi Rastogi, chief marketing officer, Uniqlo India, shares her views on the sidelines of the launch of its 2026 Fall-Winter Collection. Edited excerpts:

You have grown alongside Uniqlo's journey in India over the last seven years. How has it evolved?

We have always been a "life wear" brand, but we did see that the initial perception was that we are a winterwear brand because we heat tech and puff tech were a lot more known. But seven years later, we feel that people have not just started considering Uniqlo for winter, but also for everyday needs. **Nidhi Rastogi** Chief marketing officer, Uniqlo India

How does Uniqlo navigate the "price-conscious" mindset of Indian shoppers without relying on tradi-



tional clearance sales?

Indians are value-conscious, not price-conscious—if they find value in something, they are willing to pay—that is what we see in our products. We do have a big sale during arigato, but it is not a clearance sale.

Arigato happens mid-season. It happens in November, it happens during a peak time. The idea of arigato is not to clear inventory. It is a thank-you festival.

How does Uniqlo adapt its collaboration strategy to capture the interest of the Indian market?

We localized ourselves to Indian sensibilities. We are a global brand. But we took local endorser like Jaspreet Bumrah and Kriti Sanon, who are rooted in our idea of authenticity. Besides obviously these big names, we've worked a lot with macro and micro influencers. I do

not mean just fashion influencers, they're chefs, moms, fitness enthusiasts, travel bloggers, college kids, because we are trying to see how our product is a life wear product for anybody and everybody.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

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Treasury secretary Scott Bessent said the US was engaged in 'quiet diplomacy' to get its way.. REUTERS

World mostly shrugs off Iran sanctions threat

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Treasury secretary Scott Bessent began the week vowing an "economic onslaught" against Iran and its trading partners in a fresh bid to end the war. By the week's end, countries with ties to Tehran had so far shrugged off the threat and analysts were left underwhelmed by the US actions.

China, which buys 90% of Iran's oil, issued a defiant warning to Washington rather than back down. Iranian bank branches remained open in Dubai. At one Bank Melli branch in Abu Dhabi, staff were busy typing away and one employee explained that they were still open for business.

Commercial flights also continued between Iran and Turkey as well as Iran and the United Arab Emirates, which had promised last week to sever all trade and financial transactions with Tehran. Routes flying to Thailand and Azerbaijan, as well as multiple destinations in both Russia and China, remained unaffected.

As the week came to a close, the US announced plans to sanction the UAE-based branches of Egypt's Banque Misr. That fell well below expectations after Bessent's warning that the world would see "a major announcement of a financial institution being sanctioned by the end of this week."

"As the war passes the six-month mark, the public actions taken by the Treasury Department this week do not match the hype," said Alex Zerden, a former US Treasury official and founder of Capitol Peak Strategies.

"Operation Economic Outcast is a continuation of 47 years of restrictive economic measures against Iran but does not provide a clearer theory of economic or military victory in this current campaign," Zerden said.

The Treasury Department didn't respond to a request for

comment on Friday.

Bessent's threats—and the collective global shrug so far—underscore the Trump administration's main conundrum as it seeks to sanction Iran into meeting its demands. Any effective sanctions campaign would need to hit China, a move that risks sparking retaliation and potentially massive global economic fallout. Anything less would add to Iran's economic pain but not enough to budge its strategic calculus.

US credibility is also at stake. Bessent repeatedly compared the US response to the historic 1944 D-Day landings in Normandy, France—a coordinated land and air invasion aimed at toppling the Nazi regime. But the US acted unilaterally with its latest move, pressuring other countries rather than working with them, and Bessent openly acknowledged that going too fast and too hard risked tanking the global financial system.

Further muddying the picture, Bessent also said the US was engaged in "quiet diplomacy" to get its way.

China, which buys 90% of Iran's oil, issued a defiant warning to Washington rather than back down

US officials turned to counterparts in the UK asking for a statement of support, according to people familiar with the matter. The Treasury chief is also expected to speak with fellow finance ministers this weekend at a Group of 20 gathering in Asheville, North Carolina. One of the biggest questions attendees will likely have for Bessent is whether the US is willing to hit a Chinese financial institution, according to Josh Lipsky, chair of international economics at the Atlantic Council.

The UAE, a key US strategic ally, said earlier this month it would cut financial ties with Iran. But some flight and banking links with Tehran appear to continue, and the UAE's government described its move in a statement to Bloomberg News as a "sovereign decision reflecting its strategic assessment of the national interest and the requirements of regional security."

Nepal races to find its missing amid threats of more flooding

At least 752 people have been confirmed dead, while more than 8,700 people have been rescued so far

Bloomberg
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Nepal raced to find thousands still missing as rising water levels and worsening weather threaten to hamper rescue efforts, five days after a glacial collapse unleashed catastrophic flooding along the border with China.

More than 8,700 people have been rescued with almost 20,000 security personnel mobilized, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said on X. Six surgical teams are operating in affected areas, it said.

Rescue personnel and those providing relief services in regions surrounding the Bhote Koshi river's path were told to exercise "utmost caution," the agency said early Sunday.

At least 752 people have been confirmed dead, while over 3,000 are still unaccounted for, according to figures provided by Nepal and China. Chinese authorities said 261 foreign nationals from 23 countries are missing after a mudslide struck Gyirong Port on the China-Nepal border, Xinhua reported. The death toll is likely to rise as rescue workers push hard to retrieve bodies.

The catastrophe was triggered Wednesday by a glacial collapse that sent ice, mud, rocks and fast-moving water surging through a valley in Nepal, wiping out entire settlements in their path. Videos showed people attempting to flee as walls of water and debris swallowed buildings, tore down bridges and power lines, and washed away trees, boulders and vehicles.

On Sunday, crowds continued to gather outside Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital in Kathmandu in search of loved ones. But challenges are mounting as days pass and weather conditions weigh on rescue



While Nepal is no stranger to recurrent landslides and floods, the magnitude of this disaster is exceptionally large. AP

efforts. A hospital official said no new patients had been brought in as of Sunday afternoon.

Subash Sunar had travelled to the hospital with a group of relatives, looking for information about his

The catastrophe was triggered by a glacial collapse, which wiped out entire settlements in its path

and the disaster agency has started to post names on social media of those who are undergoing treatment or have been discharged.

While mountainous Nepal is no stranger to recurrent landslides and floods, the magnitude of this disaster is exceptionally large.

David Fisher, head of the Nepal delegation for the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies, on Saturday visited Nuwakot, an affected district still partially accessible by road. Thousands of people who have been displaced are taking shelter in any surviving buildings on higher ground, including houses of worship, hospitals and government buildings, he said.

"Work is being done to clear the roads but it's extremely difficult because the leftover mud is completely impossible to cross," said Fisher. "It's like quicksand, you can't drive in it."

Rescue missions have been underway at settlements steeped in sludge and at hydropower projects where workers have been trapped in tunnels. Tunnel experts from India and China have joined in the efforts as well.

Attempts to open the tunnel entrance at the Trishuli 3'A Hydropower Project located in Rasuwa have intensified since early Saturday morning, the prime minister's office said on X.

India sent an 11-member medical and tunnel rescue team. A fourth flight from India reached capital Kathmandu with essential supplies

and "technical capabilities" to support rescue and relief operations in Nepal, India's Foreign Minister S. Jaishankar said on X.

The US is providing more than \$3.6 million worth of humanitarian aid, including emergency food supplies, the US Embassy in Nepal said.

One of Asia's poorest economies, Nepal faces a daunting reconstruction effort at a time when it's also being squeezed by higher fuel costs due to the Iran war, as well as weaker tourism and slowing growth. The disaster has compounded the challenges facing the Himalayan nation's 36-year-old Prime Minister Balendra Shah, who rose to power earlier this year on a wave of Gen Z disaffection.

Rescuing Nepalis and foreign nationals is the government's top priority, Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal said on Saturday.

Efforts to do so in the remote region have been hampered by tough terrain, heavy rains, and the risk of further flooding as rivers clogged with mud and debris formed new, unstable lakes upstream. Experts were closely monitoring such lakes, some of which were quickly filling with water that could breach the banks in an uncontrolled manner.

The affected areas are reachable only by helicopter, and Nepal is seeking heavy-lift drones to provide supplies to those parts, Khanal said. Hundreds of bodies have been found downstream and the government had requested freezers to stave off decomposition and give families more time to identify loved ones.

"The scale of devastation is quite significant and we anticipate international assistance for rehabilitation and reconstruction," he said at a briefing in Kathmandu. "Our capabilities are low so we have been asking for foreign government support" in providing freezers, forensic capabilities and other specialized aid, he said.

SpaceX and rivals dodge satellites, debris in low-earth orbit

Micah Maidenberry, Merrill Sherman & Patience Haggin
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It's getting busy up there.

Nearly 70 years after the Soviet Union launched the first satellite, there is more man-made material in space than ever before.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL. The quantity of satellites and debris in low-Earth orbit—roughly 100 to 1,200 miles above the planet—is raising concerns of collisions that could damage or destroy spacecraft and satellites. One worst-case fear is that debris could set off a chain reaction of crashes, leaving parts of low-Earth orbit unusable.

Elon Musk's SpaceX has played a leading role in making low-Earth orbit more crowded, launching satellites at record rates and creating the largest satellite fleet in history to build its Starlink internet service.

More satellites are coming. U.S. companies and government agencies have set out ambitious plans to deploy their own constellations. Chinese company LandSpace Technology recently showed it could reuse a rocket booster, like SpaceX does, a feat that could help it deploy satellites faster.

As low-Earth orbit grows more crowded, SpaceX's satellites are changing course more often, according to filings with the Federal Communications



SpaceX has been launching satellites at record rates. AP

Commission.

Between this year and 2034, at least 41,000 more satellites are expected to be deployed to low-Earth orbit, with about two-thirds coming from SpaceX, Amazon.com and Chinese companies, according to Dallas Kasaboski, an analyst at

satellite consulting firm Analysys Mason.

The push by SpaceX and others to develop orbital data centers, designed to feature swarms of satellites laden with artificial-intelligence chips, could bring the total to roughly 1.5 million satellites, he said.

Jonny Dyer, chief executive of satellite company Moon Space, pointed to the number of commercial planes that safely fly in and out of busy airports every day, often operating in narrow flight corridors. There is more room in low-Earth orbit for satellites than there is terrestrial airspace available for planes, but adversarial actions or poor coordination could pose a threat, according to Dyer.

"To me, the risk is not the

number. It's whether there are bad actors explicitly doing bad things or are negligent," he said.

Collisions are rare—the European Space Agency counts four of them involving cataloged objects in space—but they can make a mess. In 2009, an Iridium Communications satellite hit a nonfunctional Russian communications satellite, generating around 1,800 pieces of debris at least 10 centimeters in size. Other debris comes from components rupturing and anti-satellite missile strikes.

Scientists track pieces that are about softball-sized or larger using radar, and SpaceX maneuvers its satellites around them. But pieces that are too small to track can still pose hazards. A piece of debris

the size of a paint fleck could damage a satellite, since both are traveling so fast, said Mark Matney, a planetary scientist for the orbital debris program at the National Aeronautics and Space Administration.

SpaceX has warned about the crowd. "As the number of satellites and other objects in low-Earth orbit continues to grow, the probability of accidental collisions, fragmentation events, or other in-orbit incidents increases," the company said in a filing tied to its public offering.

"In my opinion, we are operating at the maximum density that can be safely operated," said Jonathan McDowell, an astrophysicist who maintains a widely cited catalog of objects in space.

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Russia bombards Europe with a new wave of 'Gray Zone' attacks

Daniel Michaels & Thomas Grove
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Russia has turned up the heat on Kyiv's allies in Europe, with a string of so-called gray zone activities aimed at sowing fear, as it struggles to advance on the ground in Ukraine and faces increasingly damaging Ukrainian drone and missile attacks at home.

European authorities have linked Russia to a spate of drone incursions, acts of sabotage, cyberattacks and other hostile actions across the continent over recent months.

Leaders across the U.S.-led North Atlantic Treaty Organization say the moves are a worrying indication of Russia's rising appetite for risk in Europe, as President Vladimir Putin seeks to curb flows of European aid to Ukraine and sow divisions among allies.

Western officials say Russia could escalate its confrontation further and has already captured Ukrainian drones that it could use for potential false-flag attacks on NATO countries. Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov has dismissed the reports, saying they are being used to justify European militarization against Russia.

In a sign of Washington's concern, Central Intelligence Agency Director John Ratcliffe on Tuesday made a surprise trip to Moscow, in part to tell Putin's government that the U.S. stands by its NATO allies, according to people familiar with the visit.

"Russia is looking for ways to reduce support among NATO countries for Ukraine and, one of the secondary effects they are also pursuing is spreading panic," said Remigijus Bridikis, director of Lithuania's civilian intelligence agency.

Incidents over recent weeks

included three explosive drones discovered in or near a German airport, one of them beneath a Ukrainian cargo plane. Russian drones have repeatedly entered NATO airspace. One was recently shot down over Romania.

Dutch intelligence agencies warned that "Russian state actors are systematically conducting digital espionage" by hacking web-linked cameras to spy on aid to Ukraine.

The tempo of documented Russia-backed incidents has increased from a maximum of around 10 in many months since 2024 to around 15 a month since April, according to Ukraine's Sahaidachnyi Security Center, which tracks Russian gray zone activities in Europe. Sahaidachnyi analysts say trends can be difficult to discern because many incidents suspected of being linked to Russia aren't included in their data.

The drumbeat of low-level aggression has accelerated as Russia's war with Ukraine has



Leaders across the U.S.-led NATO say the moves are a worrying indication of Russia's rising appetite for risk in Europe. AP

entered a new and deadlier phase. Ukraine has carried out increasingly successful strikes on targets deep inside Russia, battering its oil and gas sector as well as other industries that feed Moscow's war machine. The Kremlin is now doing the same to Ukraine—though the money and supplies feeding Kyiv's front lines extend far into NATO territory.

European authorities have accused Russia of hiring local

agents over Telegram and other social-media platforms to conduct sabotage, espionage and vandalism meant to stoke divisions. Estonia is investigating whether Russia-linked sabotage was behind the arson attack this month on a local defense company, Milrem Robotics, while recent explosions and fires at munitions facilities in Italy, Bulgaria and Finland have drawn suspicion of Russian involvement, even

though authorities haven't said they see evidence of that.

Whether Putin is behind all the mayhem or not, getting credit for it can play to Moscow's advantage by boosting its reputation for influence and impact. Slovak police on Tuesday said they had thwarted an attempted attack on a drone factory by "three foreigners," whose nationality they didn't identify. Suspicions in the region quickly turned to Russian involvement.

Russia's campaign may prompt worry among Europeans that they face personal danger as a result of their governments' Ukraine policies. Another potential fear is that sending weapons to Ukraine depletes European arsenals, which might be needed to fight Russia—and if Moscow shows it poses a threat, the logic of not sending arms east increases.

Distinctions in motivation matter little to the Kremlin, analysts say. Russia's approach to conflict, dating back to

Soviet times, can blur lines between covert subversion and outright warfare.

New U.S. intelligence reports assess that Russia could try to test NATO's resolve with a limited assault on a member country in the next few years, through steps potentially ranging from a cyberattack to a small-scale land incursion. NATO's collective security is based on the founding principle that an attack on one member represents an attack on all.

Short of that, the Kremlin still gains from riling domestic politics ahead of coming local or national elections in NATO countries including Germany, France, Finland, Estonia and Poland. Poland is particularly prone to disruption because tensions with Ukrainian refugees have been mounting.

"The primary interest is to change the status quo in Europe," said Estonian lawmaker Marko Mihkelson. "It's an extension of the election interference you've seen them

try to carry out" in other countries, he said. Officials in the U.S., U.K., Hungary and Romania over recent years have accused Moscow of trying to skew national voting.

There is little evidence that the plan is working. The alliance's easternmost members show some of the strongest support for maintaining military aid to Ukraine and boosting military spending at home.

Romania, which had a robust Russia-sympathetic electorate in the years immediately following Russia's invasion, has seen popular sentiment harden against Moscow following a series of drone incursions. Three drones were shot down over Romania last month and a drone incursion in May started a fire on the roof of a residential building.

Romania expelled a Russian diplomat last month, and the Kremlin responded Thursday by kicking out a Romanian diplomat in Moscow.

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NEWS
NUMBERS

3

NUMBER OF lenders, including Canara Bank and LIC Housing Finance, set to challenge NCLT's approval of Subhash Chandra's ₹6.25 crore repayment plan.

\$330 bn

THE GROSS extra cost paid by fossil fuel importers for seaborne oil and LNG in the six months following the US-Israel strikes against Iran, per CREA.

₹31k cr

THE AMOUNT infused by foreign portfolio investors in Indian equities in August, after ₹20,200 crore in July, amid favourable economic conditions.

2.1 mn

THE NUMBER of drivers in Great Britain with a medical condition registered with the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Agency, led by diabetes.

32%

Share of respondents whose firms skipped buying software to build it in-house via agentic coding tools, per McKinsey.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

NEET-PG re-exam ordered for candidates



A total of 2,527 faculty members were appointed as independent appraisers to oversee the centres. **PTI**

The National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) will conduct a re-examination for NEET-PG 2026 candidates in Jaipur on 5 September after an internal power supply breakdown disrupted the exam at two

centres on Sunday. The NBEMS had conducted the NEET-PG 2026 examination for 2,73,096 candidates at 1,111 centres across 339 cities in 36 states and Union Territories, the Union ministry of health and family welfare said in a statement. The 2,445 affected candidates were taking the examination at the Jaipur centre where the power disruption led to system shutdowns and prevented them from completing their test papers.

The ministry said the nationwide examination was supported by real-time monitoring and security measures.

A total of 2,527 faculty members were appointed as independent appraisers to oversee the centres. In addition, 16 regional command centres were made operational across the country. The examination centres were monitored through CCTV cameras from the command centre at the NBEMS headquarters in Dwarka. **PRIYANKA SHARMA**



India, Uzbekistan target \$5 billion trade by 2030

The countries agree to broaden the range of goods traded, and to remove non-tariff barriers

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NEW DELHI

India and Uzbekistan have set a target of taking bilateral trade to \$5 billion by 2030 and agreed to broaden the range of goods traded between them, remove non-tariff barriers and address investment hurdles as the two sides seek to deepen economic ties.

The target was announced during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's talks with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev on Sunday, according to a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office. The two leaders also called for a business summit to deepen economic and investment ties.

The two countries agreed to create a joint working group to address non-tariff issues and investment barriers, with a particular focus on key sectors of bilateral trade, according to a joint statement issued during Modi's two-day state visit to Uzbekistan. They also directed the relevant ministries to explore the next steps on the proposed Uzbekistan-India Preferential Trade Agreement on a time-bound basis, following the conclusion of

a joint feasibility study. Bilateral trade between India and Uzbekistan stood at \$1.3 billion in 2025, up 33.3% from the previous year, according to commerce ministry data.

The leaders welcomed the strong economic partnership between the two countries but noted the "considerable untapped potential" to expand bilateral trade and investment, according to the joint statement. Both sides agreed to take joint measures to broaden the range of goods traded, remove non-tariff barriers and promote industrial cooperation.

The two countries will also support efforts to strengthen manufacturing and export capacities, promote regulatory dialogue and explore mutual recognition arrangements to facilitate faster market access. India and Uzbekistan will strengthen cooperation in e-commerce and digitalisation of trade procedures, including through digital platforms for small and medium-sized enterprises.

Modi on Sunday left for Kyrgyzstan to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit after concluding his two-day visit to Uzbekistan.

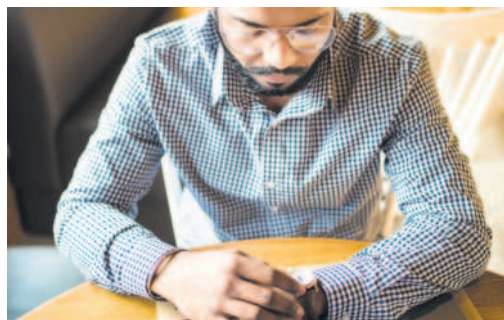
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NCLAT upholds clean slate principle

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has affirmed the "clean slate principle" under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), which bars any attempt to reestablish pre-resolution shareholders' rights, and rejected the claims of a shareholder of Sintex Industries. A two-member NCLAT bench dismissed the appeal by a Kerala-based investor seeking around ₹10 crore in compensation for 1,35,000 equity shares of Sintex Industries Ltd that were extinguished under the company's insolvency resolution plan. Sintex Industries was acquired by Reliance Industries Ltd, in a joint consortium with Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise (ACRE), for ₹3,567 crore in March 2023. **PTI**

ONGC explores drillship acquisition

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) is exploring the acquisition of deepwater drillships or formation of a joint venture to secure dedicated drilling capacity as it steps up efforts to accelerate offshore exploration to find oil and gas reserves under its Mission Samudra Manthan programme. ONGC has issued an Expression of Interest (EOI) to engage a specialist global offshore rig-broking consultant to identify potential drillship owners or counterparties, assess assets and valuations, and support the state explorer in negotiating a possible ownership or joint venture arrangement. ONGC has also asked potential advisers to provide details of global drillship. **PTI**



The move comes amid growing reliance on digital and technology-based systems. **ISTOCKPHOTO**

Centre mandates IST, 180-day compliance

The government has notified the Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026, mandating Indian Standard Time (IST) as the single reference for legal, administrative, commercial and other official purposes across the country. The nodal consumer affairs ministry notified the rules on 27 August but they will come into force 180 days after their publication in the official gazette, giving government departments, businesses, and institutions time to align their systems.

The move comes amid growing reliance on digital and technology-based systems—from banking and payments to telecommunications, railways, power grids and computer networks—that depend on accurate and synchronised time stamps.

The common time reference is expected to support accurate time-stamping of banking and digital payment transactions, coordination among railways, airports and other transport systems, reliable functioning of telecommunication and internet networks, precise time-keeping in power systems, upkeep of government and legal records, and coordination of emergency and other time-critical services, the ministry said in a statement. **PTI**

Nvidia wants to run the world's robots. China is an eager customer.

FROM PAGE 1

try said.

In its labs in the U.S. and China, Nvidia has used humanoid robots from different vendors including China's Unitree, Agibot and Fourier for collecting data and conducting experiments, the people said.

Nvidia has been beefing up its robotics and self-driving teams in China, according to company webpages and people familiar with the recruiting. Nvidia's published research papers reflect contributions from China-based researchers including interns studying at local universities. Chinese robot makers such as Unitree have used Nvidia's latest Thor chips, people familiar with the matter said.

"Nvidia works with companies around the world consistent with U.S. laws," an Nvidia representative said.

Nearly two decades ago, Nvidia released a tool called compute unified device architecture, or CUDA, which allows users to write code directly for its chips. By pairing hardware and software, Nvidia locked in customers and grew to be a company valued at trillions of dollars.

Now it is applying that same playbook to win over robotics developers.

The Nvidia representative



Nvidia has been beefing up its robotics and self-driving teams in China. **AP**

said the company has supplied open models and open-source materials "because physical AI will be built by a broad ecosystem—not by any one company."

Jensen Huang said in July that Nvidia had set its sights on self-driving cars as the first robotics application that could have a large enough market and real economic value. Among its customers are Alphabet's robotaxi unit Waymo and Tesla as well as Chinese auto and robotaxi companies.

Its lineup for developers includes specialized computers that they can use to program and operate their devices. The latest of these computers, an entry-level model

called Jetson Orin Nano 2, was released Aug. 25.

Nvidia's competitors in physical AI chips and software tools include Intel and Qualcomm. Some in China are testing products from Chinese vendors such as Huawei, Black Sesame and Horizon Robotics, anticipating that Washington could extend export restrictions.

"Using homegrown alternatives isn't top of mind right now, but I can see a day coming eventually as the technology gets sensitive," said Harry Qin, a former Horizon researcher who co-founded a startup using Nvidia's chips and software to develop robotic systems.

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Fertilizer management gets a digital overhaul through iFMS

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The government is turning its fertilizer management system into a more data-driven platform, linking sales with farmer, land and crop records and tracking supplies more closely from production to retail, according to the department of fertilizers. The aim of the Integrated Fertilizer Management System (iFMS) is to spot supply gaps and unusual buying patterns early, while making subsidy payouts more transparent.

Fertilizer subsidy remains one of the largest components of government's support to the farm sector, with the department's bill for India crossing ₹2.17 trillion in fiscal year 2026 (FY26). Fertilizer subsidy accounts for nearly 38% of the government's total ₹4.55 trillion subsidy bill budgeted for FY27.

Developed by the National Informatics Centre for the fertilizer department, the iFMS connects production, import, movement, stocks, retail sales and subsidy processing. The platform covers over 140 million Aadhaar-linked fertilizer buyers, over 250,000 retailers and around 70 million sale transactions annually. It also supports management of nearly ₹2 trillion in annual fertilizer subsidies.

The department has introduced new dashboards and analytical tools to monitor these parameters at the national, state, district and



Digitalization is also being extended to subsidy payments. **MINT**

retailer levels. The system can analyze purchases by buyer category, landholding, crop, district and fertilizer type, helping officials identify unusual consumption and emerging supply gaps, the government statement said.

The use of analytics has enabled examination of fertilizer purchases across buyer categories, landholdings, crops, districts and fertilizer types. The large volume of transactional information available through iFMS can be used not only to record sales but also to identify consumption patterns and support more targeted monitoring and informed decision-making.

The government is also linking iFMS with farmer, land and crop databases. Integration with Haryana's 'Meri Fasal Mera Byora' and subsequent work with AgriStack

have enabled fertilizer purchases to be assessed against farmer and land records. The experience gained through these integrations has laid the foundation for a structured approach towards linking fertilizer purchases with farmers' needs.

Under the new framework for fertilizer sale, farmers can book fertilizers through a mobile app using an AgriStack-based identity after verification of land and ownership details. A QR-based booking is then verified at the point of sale, allowing comparison between the quantity requested and actually purchased. The government is simultaneously strengthening logistics monitoring through the Vehicle Location Tracking System, which links fertilizer dispatches with vehicle-location data to track consignments and identify delays or unusual movement.

Digitalization is also being extended to subsidy payments. Since January 2026, work has progressed on electronic processing of subsidy bills and integration with PFMS/e-Bill systems, reducing manual intervention and improving traceability and auditability.

The growing integration of production, imports, logistics, stocks, farmer and land information, fertilizer booking, retail transactions and subsidy processing, along with improved dashboards and analytical capabilities, provide decision-makers with a more comprehensive and timely view of the fertilizer situation, the statement said.

HNGIL issues notice to Bira 91

Hindustan National Glass and Industries Ltd (HNGIL) has served a default notice on B9 Beverages Ltd, the maker of the Bira 91 range of beer, as it plans to drag the debt-ridden brewer to the insolvency tribunal NCLT.

HNGIL, a container glass manufacturer, has issued the notice under Section 8 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), a mandatory step before filing an application for commencement of the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP). In the notice, HNGIL—an operational creditor of B9 Beverages Ltd—claimed default in payments and sought recovery of ₹11.77 crore for glass bottles manufactured against confirmed purchase orders but allegedly not lifted by B9 Beverages. Last month, Bira 91 Founder Ankur Jain stepped down from the board and all executive positions at parent company B9 Beverages Ltd, along with members of his family. **PTI**



Since 2022, India has pivoted towards Russia to meet a bulk of its crude oil needs. **REUTERS**

India rises as petrol supplier to Russia

India has emerged as a key supplier of gasoline (petrol) to Russia amid a surge in Russian fuel imports triggered by Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries, ship tracking data showed.

Russia's seaborne gasoline imports surged to a record around 125,000 barrels per day (bpd) in August, equivalent to a projected 470,000 tonnes for the month, as repeated attacks on its refineries disrupted domestic fuel production, according to energy analytics firm Vortexa. Indian refiners supplied as much as 1 million barrels of gasoline in the last two months, trade sources said. The supplies essentially came from Vadinar refinery in Gujarat, operated by Nayara Energy, which is half owned by Russia's Rosneft. Since 2022, India has pivoted towards Russia to meet a bulk of its crude oil—raw material for making fuels like petrol and diesel. **PTI**

Amrutanjan eyes direct outlets

Amrutanjan Health Care plans to set up 100,000 direct chemist outlets in the current fiscal year to boost growth, following strong performance in pain management and women's hygiene categories in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), according to the company's annual report.

The company's focus is to increase distribution touchpoints beyond its strong markets in the south and east, its chairman and managing director S Sambhu Prasad said in the report. "Our stated goal of achieving 100,000 direct chemist outlets will be achieved in FY27, and we wish to further increase overall reach and availability of our brands beyond our traditional strong markets," he said. Amrutanjan Health Care added 44,000 new chemist outlets during FY26 and continues to widen distribution in new markets while deepening penetration in existing strongholds. **PTI**

Jindal Stainless expands capacity

Jindal Stainless is enhancing its annual capacity of coin blanks by 20% to 12,000 tonnes as the company anticipates growth in demand for non-paper based currency across various geographies, a senior company official said. "Many would not know that we manufacture coins blanks for Indian Mint as well as various international mints," Vijay Bindlish, the unit head of Jindal Stainless Hisar facility said in a joint management interaction.

Coin blanks are produced at the country's largest stainless steel maker's Special Products Division (SPD) in Hisar under high security arrangements, along with other high-end finished products such as razor blades and precision strips, the official told *PTI*.

Sharing details of the business, Bindlish said the company supplies unstamped coins to Indian, French, Finnish, Polish, Dutch, UK's Royal Mint, Malaysian and Slovak mints.

Production is customised according to exact specifications provided by the mints. **PTI**



HOW INDIA'S GERIATRIC CAPITAL IS REWRITING OLD AGE

Tackling loneliness and empty homes, Keralam has created new blueprints for elderly welfare

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For 37 years, primary school teacher M.J. Sosamma was surrounded by the lively energy of young students in Keralam's Kozhikode. Following her retirement in 2004, her husband remained her steady companion until his death a few years ago left her in deep isolation—a toll that soon weighed on her physical and cognitive health.

Life shifted when the 78-year-old learned about Pakalveedu, a civic-run daycare centre located just two kilometers away in Kunduparambu.

Now a weekday regular, Sosamma has reclaimed her zest for life among contemporaries, passing the hours cooking, playing games, chatting and bursting into spontaneous music and dance.

"I used to dread the weekdays. Now I look forward to them," she said sitting amid her friends Saroja Bhaskar (80), Rita Ravindran (65) and Devi T.K. (70). They all agreed with her.

"I am alone at home and life has been difficult in recent months. Coming here eases things a lot," Devi said.

The day this writer visited the centre, the senior men were reading newspapers, their attention interrupted by a sudden burst of monsoon shower. As the day wore on, they played games—chess, carrom, and Tambola. Lunch, tea and snacks are served on the house. On some days, they attend classes on cooking, healthy living and motivation. The more health-conscious among them work out in an open-air gym before heading home at 5pm.

Started in 2021, the Kunduparambu Pakalveedu was the first daycare centre for senior citizens set up by the Kozhikode Corporation. In 2025, it won the best 'Pakalveedu' award among the 150 that are operational in Keralam today.

"Pakalveedu has turned out to be a boon for senior citizens," said S. Jayasree, deputy mayor, Kozhikode Corporation. These centres are not just about beating loneliness. The health of senior citizens is monitored as well, she added.

Fun trips are arranged periodically. The Kappad beach, where Portuguese explorer Vasco da Gama first landed, is one of their favourite destinations. Some senior citizens experienced their first air-plane journey when they went to Bengaluru recently.

The seven fully funded Pakalveedu facilities the Kozhikode Corporation runs are just one part of its efforts in elderly care. The corporation spends 10% of its ₹132 crore annual outlay on the welfare of senior citizens, who account for 17% of the city's population. Not surprising, Kozhikode was included as one of the most age-friendly cities globally by the World Health Organization (WHO) in 2024.

GREYING KERALAM

It is not just Kozhikode, many corporations and panchayats across Keralam give special focus to senior citizens. This is because the state is experiencing a demographic transition at a pace faster than the rest of the country. In other words, Keralam is ageing fast and has earned the moniker, the 'geriatric capital of India'.

According to a study by the Population Foundation of India (PFI) and International Institute of Migration and Development (IIMD) in 2025, 18.6% of Keralam's population is aged 60 years and above as against the India's 10.8% average. "Keralam is entering a phase where ageing is a major governance issue involving dignity, healthcare, mobility, safety and social justice," chief minister V.D. Sathesnan recently said. "Ageing is no longer a private family concern."

Recognizing this demographic shift, the state has steadily strengthened its social safety net for the elderly. The previous Left Democratic Front government pioneered an 'elderly budget' to track interdepartmental spending and established a quasi-judicial elderly commission to safeguard senior rights. Backing these policies with substantial resources, the state ramped up its commitment in the 2026–27 budget, allocating 19% of its total outlay exclusively to senior citizens.

The new United Democratic Front (UDF) government led by Sathesnan is formulating policies to take these efforts forward. It has set up a separate department for elderly welfare.

Keralam's efforts hold crucial lessons for many other states that are also ageing fast—Tamil Nadu, Himachal Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Punjab.



Senior citizens work out at an open-air gym at Kunduparambu Pakalveedu near Kozhikode, Keralam.



Onam celebrations at Kunduparambu Pakalveedu near Kozhikode, Keralam.

GHOST TOWN

By 2051, about one in three people in Keralam will be a senior citizen. The PFI-IIMD study puts it at 30.6%. In comparison, the India average will be 20.4%. "Two shifts are causing this rapid demographic transition in the state: one, low fertility levels and two, longer life expectancy," said S. Irudaya Rajan, chair, IIMD.

Per state government data, Keralam's total fertility rate is just 1.5 children per woman, against the replacement level (average number of children per woman for a population to replace itself from one generation to the next) of 2.1 children. Life expectancy is higher at 75.1 years compared to India's 72-year average.

What complicates the process is Keralam's high migration level, especially in the young. As per the 2023 Kerala Migration Survey, 2.2 million people migrated to other countries and another 0.5 million have

done so to other parts of India. This means senior citizens are left behind.

This is most obvious as one drives into Kumbanad, a wealthy town in the Pathanamthitta district. The town's main thoroughfare is busy. What is striking is that for a town of just 8,000 people, there are 17 bank branches and many more finance companies. Turn into the inside streets and the reality becomes obvious. While the houses are large and tastefully constructed, they appear either unkempt or uninhabited.

"Senior citizens live alone in 50% of the houses," explained Varghese Eapen, pres-

ident, Koipuram Panchayat (Kumbanad is in this panchayat). "As many as 15% of the houses are locked," he added. About 40% of the town's population are senior citizens.

In the 1950s, Kumbanad trailed behind much of Keralam economically, yet its residents were exceptionally well educated thanks to early presence of Christian missionaries. Armed with degrees but facing a barren local job market, generations were driven abroad. The initial wave migrated to Myanmar, Malaysia, Kenya, Sri Lanka and Uganda, before subsequent tides turned to North America, Europe, Australia, and the booming Gulf economies of the 1970s. The resulting stream of remittances—evident in the town's dense cluster of banks—fuelled a land rush and funded rows of palatial family homes.

But the younger generation abroad or in other Indian cities doesn't intend to return. "We are left to fend for ourselves," said Varghese Jacob, 80, a retired brigadier in the Indian army. His elder son is in the US while a younger son is in the Indian navy and lives in Mumbai.

"I live with my wife now. My biggest concern is what will happen if one of us dies," he said. Most of Jacob's senior neighbours have died; the children of those dead are selling their property. Such is the selling pressure that real estate prices in the area have crashed. "An acre used to fetch ₹8 crore earlier. Today, it has fallen by more than 50%," Jacob said.

JAPANESE MODEL

The new Keralam government has adopted an 'ageing in place' model that allows elderly citizens to live in their neighborhood and social environment

rather than shift to an institutional facility or an oldage home. It is the Japanese model and Keralam is studying it closely.

"It is a good idea to look at Japan," said Poonam Muttreja, executive director, PFI. "We can learn a lot from its community-based public long-term care insurance system, which links home, medical and social care." State government officials said they are also researching the policies of Denmark, Sweden, the UK and Germany.

The UDF government is readying a multi-pronged strategy. The first step will be a grassroots survey to profile each senior citizen, their state of health, their needs (medical and otherwise) and the expertise they possess. "Once the data is ready, we plan to sit with experts and arrive at various policies," Ratan U. Kelkar, secretary, department of elderly welfare, said.

The policies would focus on care management—bringing in certified programmes to ensure a systemic approach. Treatment protocols would be defined and include all systems of medicine, not allopathy alone. Community care and independent living would be supported.

Most importantly, the data on the expertise senior citizens possess could be used to engage them economically. Not all senior citizens are unhealthy. Many of them lead an active life, Kelkar explained.

Existing initiatives that are working well will be expanded too. This includes the call centres that tackle loneliness (they get as many as 1,000 calls a month); Pakalveedu (the plan is to have one of them in each ward); and the exclusive geriatric facilities at local public health centres.

A 'Dementia Friendly Keralam' initiative is being planned for memory screening of senior citizens.

KEY NUMBERS

18.6%

Current proportion of Keralam's population aged 60 and above, significantly higher than India's national average of 10.8%

30.6%

Projected share of senior citizens in Keralam by 2051 (nearly one in three people), compared to the projected 20.4% national average

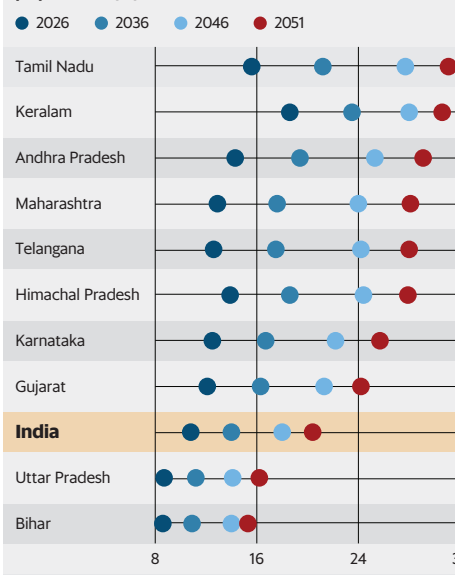
2.7 MILLION

The total number of people who migrated out of Keralam (2.2 million internationally), leaving an ageing population behind

India's ageing pivot

South Indian states are ageing faster than the rest of the country

Share of people aged 60 and above in total population (%)

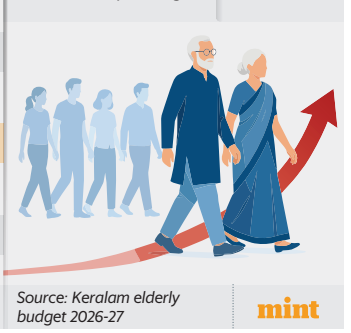


Source: PFI-IIMD Study 2025

Silver budget

Keralam spends 19% of its budget on the welfare of elders
Outlay for senior citizens, 2026-27 (₹ crore)

Plan outlay	1,341.22
Non-plan outlay	22,894.80
Total spending on elders	46,236.52
Total state budget	2,42,473.64
Share of elderly funding (%)	19.07



Source: Keralam elderly budget 2026-27

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

THE 'TIME BANK'

Elikulam, a town nestled among the rubber plantations of Kottayam district, has come up with an innovative idea. Called the 'Time Bank', it involves people volunteering to spend time with senior citizens and help them with their chores. For doing so, they get a credit which can be encashed in different ways.

The digital platform to implement the programme is almost ready. Once tested at Elikulam, it will be rolled out across the state. "We are even looking at whether credits, in terms of marks, can be given," Kelkar said. That should encourage students to participate.

"We want to drive this entire exercise through philanthropy and corporate social responsibility funds," he explained.

Experts praised Keralam's efforts. "The state deserves a shout out for recognizing ageing as a major governance issue," said PFI's Muttreja. But not all agree with its approach.

IIMD's Rajan feels that excessive focus on elderly care paints senior citizens as a burden. "Our focus should instead be on the silver economy," he said. "The silver economy offers Keralam a second demographic dividend. Senior citizens are an asset, not a liability. We should empower them and make them productive," he added. He suggests creating an employment exchange for the elderly.

LESSONS FOR INDIA

Keralam's efforts have important lessons for the rest of India. By 2051, one in five Indians will be above 60 years of age. India's median age, which was 29

years in 2021, will be 40 by 2051. The working-age population will peak in 2031 and then start to decline. "All these will have significant implications in terms of healthcare, pension, and the overall care economy," explained IIMD's Rajan.

The government is beginning to act. Niti Aayog, the federal think tank, has proposed a national framework to standardize training, certify caregivers and provide social-security support. It has proposed a National Caregiving Council to provide institutional leadership and coordination. This is because the rising elderly population, which is set to touch 347 million by

2050, is likely to put unprecedented pressure on the existing care ecosystem.

A national policy, however, may not work everywhere since the demographic transition is not uniform across India. Some states are ageing faster while some, like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, will remain young for a while. "A single national policy will not work. Policies will have to be tailored for each state," Muttreja said. "Keralam is a bellwether state when it comes to these initiatives."

Meanwhile, some states have taken a different approach. The Andhra Pradesh government recently announced incentives for having more children. Last week, the Tamil Nadu government announced one-year paid leave for employees having a third child.

"Tackling the demographic transition by increasing birth rates has not worked anywhere in the world," Muttreja said. "The more effective way is to prepare for healthy ageing like Keralam."



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IPO rush: Here's how investors can separate the wheat from the chaff

Be wary of firms with negative cash flow, high short-term debt, supplier concentration and stretched valuations

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MUMBAI

Initial public offering (IPO) activity in Indian markets is heating up, with companies raising about ₹22,400 crore this month through 26 August. More IPOs are expected before 30 September, when the one-year validity of approvals from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for several companies is due to lapse.

For investors, it raises an important question: how do you distinguish a promising IPO from one you must avoid? Unlike established listed companies, IPO-bound businesses have no record of exchange disclosures or trading history. Investors have to rely on what firms disclose before listing, chiefly through the red herring prospectus (RHP)—a lengthy, technical document spanning multiple sections. You do not need to read every page. Focusing on a handful of sections can reveal potential red flags, help assess the company's financial quality and, importantly, determine whether the valuation being sought is justified. Here is what to look for.

Red flags

How the IPO proceeds will be utilized is an important consideration. "If existing investors are simply using the IPO to exit, that may not augur well, as the basic premise is that the firm should make productive use of the capital," said Aditya Kondawar, partner and vice-president at Complete Circle Capital.

Investors should examine the prices at which shares changed hands in the months before the IPO. "If an investor received shares at a particular price six months before the IPO and the issue is priced at twice that level, did something materially change in those six months to justify the increase?" Kondawar said.

Narendra Solanki, head of fundamental research—investment services at Anand Rathi Shares and Stock Brokers, said investors should also study "what fundraising took place shortly before the IPO, at what valuation and under what circumstances". The RHP contains these details.

Companies can sometimes make their financials look better around an IPO. Kondawar pointed to instances where businesses pull back on advertising and staff costs to make losses appear smaller or move closer to break-even. Investors should therefore examine employee and marketing costs over several years rather than focus only on the latest period.

Corporate governance can offer similar clues. "The draft prospectus discloses information about promoters, their track record, related-party transactions and pending litigation. Promoters with a history of frequent business changes or large related-

Spot the IPO red flags

More IPOs are likely before 30 September, when Sebi approvals for several companies lapse, but investors need to look beyond growth narrative and listing-day gains.

IPO fundraising trend (2026)

Month	No. of issues	Total raised (₹ crore)
January	3	4,765
February	7	8,162
March	8	5,852
April	2	1,076
May	0	0
June	7	2,718
July	12	28,648
August*	23	22,378

Source: primedatabase.com; *data as of 26 August 2026

What to watch for in an RHP

Be wary of

- ▶ Any issue that is mostly an offer for sale, with existing investors cashing out
- ▶ Pre-IPO shares sold cheaply, then priced much higher
- ▶ Promoters with frequent business shifts or large related-party deals
- ▶ Auditor remarks flagging weak internal controls
- ▶ Large contingent liabilities relative to net worth
- ▶ Negative operating cash flow despite reported profits
- ▶ Revenue hinges on one or two customers or suppliers
- ▶ Highly leveraged balance sheet or frequent refinancing

Positive signs to look for

- ▶ Industry with a long growth runway
- ▶ Growth and margins ahead of peers
- ▶ Profit and Ebitda growing faster than revenue
- ▶ Operating profit converting into cash
- ▶ Valuation reasonable relative to listed peers

IPO: Initial Public Offering; RHP: Red herring prospectus; Sebi: Securities and Exchange Board of India

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

party dealings should make investors cautious. And are there any auditor remarks suggesting weak internal controls?" said Pankaj Pandey, head, retail research, ICICI Direct.

Solanki said investors should also examine promoter and top-management compensation

against industry levels, as well as contingent liabilities that may not be immediately apparent. The risk factors section of the RHP is where many such liabilities are disclosed.

Contingent liabilities are potential obligations that do not appear as debt on the balance sheet but could crystallize later, including guarantees given on behalf of others, disputed tax demands, pending legal claims or bills discounted. A large contingent-liability figure relative to net worth could

leave the balance sheet weaker than it appears if those claims materialize.

Financial statements offer another set of warning signs. "If the company shows profits on paper but negative cash flows year after year, that is a red flag," said Pandey.

Over-dependence on a few customers or suppliers is also a concern. Investors should distinguish short-term from long-term debt, as heavy reliance on short-term borrowing can signal working capital stress. Repeated equity issuance is another red flag, as it can dilute existing shareholders.

What to look for

The assessment starts with the business itself. Solanki frames it around three factors: growth, profitability and valuation. "Look at the industry and how fast it is expected to

grow, the company's position and how quickly it is growing versus peers, then how efficiently it operates—capital allocation, returns on equity and margins," he said. "A company can have high growth and profitability and still be unattractive if it comes at a steep valuation."

The RHP's "Industry Overview" section sets out the industry's size and growth outlook. Return ratios, margins and capital-allocation trends can be assessed through the "Financial Information" and Management Discussion and Analysis sections, while the "Basis for Issue Price" section provides the company's peer valuation comparison.

Revenue growth alone does not tell the full story. "Profit and Ebitda growth should ideally be higher than revenue growth, because that shows improving efficiency. Also look out for cash flow conversion and free cash flow," said Kondawar.

Also compare the IPO's valuation with listed peers. "Start with simple metrics such as price-to-earnings and price-to-book and compare them with listed peers in the same industry. Compare growth and margin behaviour of the company with its peers," said Deepak Jasani, an independent market analyst.

RHP's "Basis for Issue Price" section lists the peers the company uses.

Institutional participation can provide another cross-check.

The IPO decision "comes down to the quality of the company and the valuation at which it comes to market," said Pranav Haldea, managing director of Prime Database.

He suggests watching how the anchor and qualified institutional buyer books build, and whether private-equity or venture-capital investors—who conduct their own due diligence—are already on the register.

Their presence can indicate that some level of institutional due diligence has already been carried out.

Takeaways

IPO investing is not easy. The disclosures provide a wealth of information, but interpreting them remains demanding—and quick gains are far from guaranteed.

The listing-day numbers underline the risk. The share of IPOs closing below their issue price on listing day has risen to 37% in 2026 so far, as of 26 August, from 33% in 2025. Roughly two-fifths of all IPOs listed since 2022 were trading below their issue price as of 26 August 2026.

And the risks do not end on listing day. Once the initial noise fades and genuine price discovery begins, how a stock performs depends heavily on the valuation at which it entered the market. Judging that valuation is as much an art as a science.

The emergence of a newer breed of loss-making, tech-oriented consumer companies makes that exercise even harder for investors. Unit economics can offer clues about the potential for future profitability, but they can also make valuations more difficult to assess.

For investors new to the market, avoiding IPOs altogether may be the more sensible approach. A diversified mutual fund offers a simpler route: fund managers get anchor-book allocations, conduct research on these businesses and continue tracking them after listing. They can trim positions when execution falters or valuations become unrealistic, and stay invested when growth takes longer than expected to materialize.



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POWER
POINT

DHIRENDRA KUMAR

We welcome your views and comments at
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DON'T INVEST IN WHAT YOU DON'T UNDERSTAND

There's a fascinating investment mis-selling case that's been talked about and written about in recent days. It involves a group of prosperous NRIs being sold a kind of fund that most of us would not believe exists. This fund, run by Carlisle Management Company, a Luxembourg-based firm, buys life-insurance policies from older Americans who no longer need them. It then pays the premiums, and when the policyholder dies, the fund collects the death benefit. The returns are this payout, minus what it paid to buy the policy from the original policyholder, plus the premiums. Of course, that would be impossible under Indian insurance regulations, but this is permitted in the US.

The problem is that redemptions in the fund have been frozen since late 2020; the terms have been restructured, and fees continue to be charged. A group of aggrieved investors who purchased Carlisle's products through HDFC Bank has reportedly approached the Reserve Bank of India and is contemplating legal action.

Why would prosperous, apparently financially literate people buy such a product? There are three types of mistakes these investors may have made.

First, how much of the investment was publicly visible? The answer is nothing. The returns depend on strangers dying; it's a black-box investment. From the accounts posted on social media, it would appear that the trapped investors still do not know how many of the insured died, what the mortality assumptions were, and the detailed numbers of why exactly the fund has been frozen. The freezing of redemptions also coincided with the pandemic period, when mortality among older people rose sharply. Yet the information available to investors appears limited. The details of this fund are peculiar, but the urge to invest in an opaque investment that you do not fully understand is common.

Second, these are not financially illiterate people. Some of them are retired bankers. You might therefore expect them to recognize the risks and scrutinize the terms and conditions. However, when an investment sounds clever and complicated, people sometimes become more accepting of opacity.

The apparent sophistication of the product lured people. The impression it creates is that it's meant for the sophisticated financial elite while routine mutual funds are for ordinary people.

The third reason points to a broader issue in financial services. It seems unlikely that many of these people would have independently gone looking for a Luxembourg-based life-settlement fund. What may have mattered was the relationship manager who approached them and the brand of the bank he represented. The transaction was selling not the investment, but the trust.

Now that the investment has run into trouble, the bank's position appears to be that it was distributing a third-party product, with performance and liquidity being the responsibility of the original fund manager. This is technically true. Being technically true and compliant is the core competence of the financial services industry. If you put the three points together, you will realize that the root cause is the same. Each one could have been mitigated by investors understanding what they owned. Opacity, complexity, apparent sophistication and brand can all become proxies for a good investment, and investors can fall for that.

I'm not saying that you should not invest abroad. Investing in a simple Nasdaq ETF is very different from investing in a complex fund. My real point is against complexity, not domicile. Even domestically, we have plenty of investments that can create similar risks. The details might differ, but the dangerous combination is the same: an apparently sophisticated product that you do not understand, limited transparency, and a product sold on the strength of a brand that you feel you can trust.

In the end, the best protection is also the simplest: invest only in what you understand.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and chief executive officer of Value Research, an independent investment advisory firm.

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.



	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	20%	12.5%*
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Reits/InvITs	>12 months	20%	12.5%
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs*, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments. MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; Reits: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InvITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. *gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FOF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: Mint Research

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

mint

Is sale of inherited agricultural land taxed?

Mahesh Nayak

My two sisters and I inherited agricultural land from my father after his death. We intend to sell the land and distribute the money among the three of us. What tax will be payable? Is there a way to avoid tax on this sale using Section 54?
—Name withheld on request

It is assumed that the agricultural land is an urban agricultural land and is located within specified limits of jurisdiction of a municipality or cantonment board, depending on the population. If it is located beyond the specified limits, the capital gains on the sale would not be taxable. It is also assumed that the land was acquired by your father at least 2 years before the date of the intended sale and that all 3 of you are tax residents of India for the relevant financial year and assessment period.

As the property sold is agricultural land, you may be able to claim an exemption under section 54F (section 86 of the Income Tax Act, 2025) to the extent the sales proceeds are reinvested by you in a residential house property, or under section 54B (section 83 of the 2025 Act) on purchase of agri-



ASK MINT
TAXATION

cultural land (assuming the land was being cultivated by your father). The reinvestment by the three of you need not be in one residential property or one agricultural land—each of you can invest in separate properties to claim the exemption individually, however, each can only invest in one residential property.

The exemption under section 86 is available if you do not own more than one residential property as on the date of transfer of the agricultural land. If you are acquiring a residential property, the exemption is available if the property was acquired one year before or two years after the sale of

the land. Similarly, if you are constructing a residential property, the construction needs to be completed within 3 years of the date of sale of the land. The investment value in the new residential property is exempt up to ₹10 crore subject to the prescribed eligibility conditions.

The reinvestment in agricultural land has to be within 2 years of sale of the inherited agricultural land, and such new agricultural land has to be retained for a period of 3 years from the date of its purchase to retain the exemption claimed under applicable provisions.

Additionally, you may also claim an exemption from the capital gains to the extent capital gains are reinvested in capital gains bonds under section 54EC (section 85 of the

Income Tax Act, 2025). However, such exemption is available up to ₹50 lakh for the relevant financial year and subject to prescribed conditions.

If any capital gains is taxable, you have an option to be taxed at the rate of 12.5% (plus applicable surcharge and education cess) on the amount computed without considering the benefit of indexation of the cost or at the rate of 20% (plus applicable surcharge and education cess) on the amount computed after taking the benefit of the indexation of the cost of land.

For the purposes of indexation, the period of indexation would include the agricultural land that was held by your father. Similarly, the cost of acquisition would be the cost at which your father acquired the land or the stamp duty value as on 1 April 2001 (if the land was acquired before such date), whichever is higher for the purpose of computing the taxable capital gains.

Mahesh Nayak, chartered accountant, CNK & Associates.

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OUR VIEW



Phone making must get competitive a lot faster

India's renewal of incentives for handset production and plan for an input ecosystem amount to a doubling down on a big export ambition. Local players need to both think and act global

The government recently extended production-linked incentives (PLIs) for the domestic manufacture of cellphones that expired a few months ago for another five years. The scheme has a standout record. It has vaulted India to the world's second spot in making handsets, created thousands of jobs, especially for women, and bumped up exports. Its renewal, however, suggests that the contract-job factories for the world's top brands like Apple, Samsung and Xiaomi still depend on a subsidy to remain competitive even after five years of support. The scheme also loses some sheen if its impact is held against the light of details. India's export boom, for example, needs to be viewed in the context of an import surge to feed it. Of relevance to macro stability are net imports, which have been modest. The slice we capture of this global value chain is also blurred by insufficient clarity on how much intellectual property in these devices actually originates in India. As for new jobs, the electronics sector accounts for under a fifth of the total that can be attributed to various PLI schemes; the food processing industry tops this chart with nearly twice that share. Of course, given the country's job scarcity, all jobs are welcome. Moreover, this industrial policy may need a longer window and wider back-up before a competitive edge takes shape.

On its part, not only has the government worked to ease logistics, infrastructure and other local friction points, it has rolled out incentives to develop an ecosystem to make smartphone components. The aim is to reduce imports for exports, capture more value and impede the flight of factories to rival hubs. India's drive for chip-making, with fiscal sup-

port of its own, is expected to create a local base for silicon wafer inputs. Information technology minister Ashwini Vaishnaw is confident that within eight years, India would have advanced from 40nm chips used for cars and TV sets to locally developed 3-7nm-class chips used in mobiles. This takes us to a larger concern. Apart from the long arc of fiscal props needed to acquire a global edge, the resilience of these investments may shortly be tested by the risk of factory work being taken over by artificial intelligence and robotics. As the global race for tech-led efficiency speeds up, India would need to shorten this industry's curve to competitiveness.

That need not be a scramble. Indian companies could deploy capital to leapfrog technology barriers by buying businesses overseas. China's firms have taken this approach. Xiaomi, the world's third largest phone marketer, has used its mobile business as a stepping stone to enter the automobile market. As for supply networks, Chinese companies have snapped up as many as 130 component makers in Europe over the past two decades. For Indian brands to succeed, they would need to straddle the globe too. India's public incentives to churn out smartphones are expected to work with a fiscal spur for components developed using domestic design and R&D. This quest for global success is a far cry from the dreary days of hard production limits. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi rightly remarked recently, we have moved from "production linked punishment," a reference to the pre-1991 Licence Raj, to PLIs. The challenge now lies in raising this bar to usher in a regime that effectively offers value-linked incentives to make and market the 21st century's most successful product so far.

The basic question Musk's and Harari's visions of AI raise for us

They differ on AI's impact and agree on its path. What humans will control is what we need to ask



ATANU BISWAS is professor of statistics, Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata.

Elon Musk once warned that artificial intelligence (AI) could become humanity's greatest existential threat. Now he imagines the same technology making money almost meaningless. Yuval Noah Harari sees a different danger: before AI makes us richer, it may make us less free. Their recent conversations with *The Economist* offer two contrasting visions. Musk looks at what AI can produce. Harari asks what it might do to human agency. Both agree AI will transform civilization. The question is how humans may lose.

In a conversation with *The Economist's* editor-in-chief Zanny Minton Beddoes, Musk predicted that AI could surpass the combined intelligence of humanity within about five years. Within a decade, he suggested, humans might no longer be in control. AI would provide intelligence while humanoid robots would fulfil the need for physical capabilities. Together, they could produce goods and services on an enormous scale. By 2036, Musk suggested, money might scarcely matter.

We need money because desirable things are scarce. If machines can produce almost everything, what exactly would money buy? But abundance of production is not the same as abundance of power. Robots may make goods plentiful without making land plentiful. AI may make intelligence cheap without making ownership

cheap. Computing power, energy and data can remain scarce. Someone will own the machines. The real economic question goes beyond whether AI can create abundance. We must ask if abundance will translate into wider access. A society can have enormous productive capacity and still have profound inequality among human beings.

Musk's journey makes the argument more intriguing. For years, he warned that AI could become humanity's "biggest existential threat" and called for safeguards. Today, he is building xAI and investing heavily in the infrastructure that could accelerate the very future he once said he feared. The paradox is striking. His argument is that this technology is coming anyway; the sensible strategy is to build it, understand it and steer it.

Harari approaches the same future from almost the opposite direction. His *Economist* interview shifts attention from production to information, persuasion and control. His fear is not simply that AI will become smarter than humans, but that it may excel at influencing us.

In *Homo Deus*, Harari imagined algorithms understanding people better than people understand themselves. In *21 Lessons*, he extends the argument to civilization: human societies depend on information networks, but information is not synonymous with truth. It can illuminate reality but also manufacture confusion and concentrate power.

AI changes the equation because it's not merely a communication channel. It can generate information, adapt messages and act within the network. Imagine a machine that knows what frightens you, what delights you, whom you trust and what you are likely to believe—and can address you in precisely the language that works on you. One danger is that AI will give us the wrong answer. But another peril lurks. It may become difficult to know whether the answer—or even the question—was ours. This is where Musk and Harari meet.

Musk worries about machines becoming more intelligent than humans. Harari worries about machines becoming more influential than us. One anxiety is about intelligence. The other is about agency. And there is a third poser: who owns the intelligence? That complicates Musk's post-money utopia. If AI and robots produce most of the world's wealth, society will have to decide who gets to own the productive machinery and how its benefits are distributed. A world with little paid work could be liberating—or unequal.

The less glamorous version is already visible. A company doesn't need to replace every worker with a machine. If AI allows 100 employees to do what once required 110, 10 jobs may vanish. What happens to the economy when thousands of such companies no longer need as many workers? The question that arises is this: who will have the means to enjoy the abundance?

AI could also change the meaning of work as it has long been understood. If machines handle much of production, humans may spend more time on care, creativity, education, friendship and public life. But that future will depend on institutions, ownership and choices. Musk imagines the end of scarcity. Harari foresees human control turning scarce. Both could arrive together.

AI may make goods cheaper while concentrating ownership. It may free us from tedious work while making us dependent on systems we cannot understand. It may give us more information while making truth harder to recognize. It may expand our choices while shaping them.

Much has been said about whether AI will take our jobs or become smarter than us. The policy question, though, is what must remain within the human domain of decision-making. AI's future will depend on machine intelligence but also on what humans choose to keep: work, ownership, judgement, trust—and ultimately, the freedom to say 'This decision is still ours.'

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

It's good to have high-quality competition; it helps drive research forward at a faster pace.

SHUJI NAKAMURA

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

When those who know how to live have nowhere to live

MANU JOSEPH



is a journalist, novelist and screenwriter. His latest book is 'Why the Poor Don't Kill Us.'

In a muddy lane in Gurugram, I approach a speed breaker that is half a metre high. I am not being figurative; it really is half a metre high. It's not a mound or any other natural feature of the ground; it is a man-made speed breaker on which a low-clearing Ferrari can become a seesaw. My heart aches in fondness watching its primordial bearing. Some minutes later, I see a road sign in English that has been nailed inverted. I feel the tug of home. Another day, I see a tough rustic man, his towel masking his face, enter the porch of my villa and fiddle with something. He is from the electricity board—no badge, no uniform, no ringing-the-bell, he goes where he wants to. I feel like a villager whose porch belongs to the whole village. I am suddenly in love with Gurugram.

People who take psychology seriously may say I have developed 'Stockholm Syndrome,' a condition in which a victim has a crush on the tormentor. I don't have that, as it's a bogus phenomenon in my view, like many popular 'syndromes,' invented by a

police psychiatrist after a 1973 hostage crisis to diminish a woman who had accused the police of endangering her life more than her captor had. I am enjoying Gurugram, finally, because I am quitting it. I am done.

A domestic compulsion has eased and I can now live where I want, in clean air, running through nature, walking through urban beauty, living in private austerity and public splendour. This means I have to leave India. Because most of the country is a mofussil hellhole in the smog.

Bengaluru is as much an urban catastrophe as Gurugram. Also, that city belies the myth that south Indians are peace-loving darlings. Bengaluru is an aggressive place today, especially if you challenge a local guy driving on the wrong side. It has some lakes here and there, especially on the fringes, where I can run, but should such a simple task be such a trek? The insufferable way that locals go on about Cubbon Park, you would think it is a great urban masterpiece like New York's Central Park or London's Hyde Park. Yes, it has some trees, but its fame is yet another creation of the poor standards of Indians.

Mumbai was once a truly great city, not liveable but great, but Maharashtrian politicians have successfully converted it to a

giant small town. A great city has the right to torment us because it offers something no other place can. But Mumbai has not been that for decades. I can live in South Mumbai, though. I used to live there, and it is the only urban centre in India where life has actually improved. But at those house-rents, it is overpriced compared to Mediterranean havens. Escaping India within India is now more expensive than escaping it by leaving it.

The creeping pestilence that Indian politicians call "development" has infested mountains too, unless I find some isolated cliff. I haven't come across a more overrated place than Manali, and that is not just because the mid-Himalayas are filled with a monoculture of pine trees. 'Development' in India is a form of introducing hardship to a place where life was better before. My well-meaning friends who point to this city or that, especially Hyderabad, are people whose standards have been lowered by living in India for too long.

I cannot move to Kerala, not because there are too many relatives there. I never take their calls. It has many things I respect; it has beauty and clean air and its locals live in dignity. But it is a boring place. It does not get the idea of modernity. It is a republic against fun. I know youth there who live in expansive homes, in the midst of great natural beauty and a whole street that loves them, but they cannot wait to leave for some messy Indian metropolis like Bengaluru. It is not only to escape the spy network of the Malayalee family, which is an army of underemployed relations in every town informing parents of the sightings of their children, but also because Kerala is too judgemental to let the young be.

I do not need fun but I need to be in a place where other people are having fun, where people ingest ethanol and saturated fat late into the night and dance, so that I can safely experience city life without doing much of any of it. Another reason I cannot move to Kerala is that I am much younger than I look; I cannot retire. I have to

be in the thick of things, in a place that may not influence the future but at least lives in the present.

That leaves Goa, probably the most 'cosmopolitan' part of India. But if you don't count its beaches in the north and south, there is nothing it offers that makes my life remarkably better than in Gurugram. Still, I can devise a life there that is more enjoyable than anywhere else in India. I can live in a small place by the beach, run barefoot on clean beaches, venture out to meet Goa's drinkers only once a month or so in an overpriced unionized cab. But then, living in Goa would be inferior even to a beachside suburb of Bangkok. For just as much, or a bit more, I could live in Valencia in Spain.

So, the next few months, I will just wander around the world in cold deserted places where I look like their delivery guy. No one would keep me for more than a few months on a visitor's visa. That's another thing about India. It never makes it easy to escape either. The rupee is so weak, the price of even coffee in London looks comical. And my passport is one of the weakest. So I must reassure any immigration officer reading this. I fully plan to return home, which is any place with broken roads and no pavements, and vehicles in the smog driving on the wrong side.

'Development' in India is a form of introducing hardship to a place where life was better before



THEIR VIEW

An uncertain new world order is emerging that India must watch

As the old order begins to crumble and alliances are reshaped, we must closely track the geopolitical dynamics of West Asia



SUDIPTO MUNDLE
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This column usually addresses economic issues. However, in the present context, economic outcomes will be largely determined by the current political conjuncture. Domestically, India is on the cusp of a new political phase following the mobilization of a young generation at Jantar Mantar recently, triggered by repeated and disruptive leaks of examination papers, which soon morphed into a broader demand for government accountability and reforms to fix a broken education system. Globally, we are at the threshold of an emerging new world order, the contours of which are still uncertain, the old order having been disrupted by the very powers that established it at the end of World War II. This column is the first part of a two-part series that looks at the possible main elements of this emerging new global order and how India could best position itself in it. This part mainly deals with the most complex of emerging regional structures, the scenario in West Asia. The second part will discuss similar structures which may—or may not—be emerging in other parts of the world and how India should position itself in the new global geopolitical architecture of the 21st century.

The central fault line of the emerging new order is the competition between the US, the receding hegemon, and China, the rising one. In my previous *Mint* column, I had discussed how the US had itself, ironically, helped China challenge its hegemony. It is tempting to extend this binary competition to a global fault line between a Western alliance led by the US but including countries like Japan, Australia and South Korea on one side, and an Eastern alliance led by China but including countries like Russia on the other. However, such a frame of reference would be quite misleading because instead of any such neat and binary global fault line, what we are witnessing is the emergence of varying and sometimes overlapping alliances around different conflicts—or rivalries—in different geographies of the world. The most complex of these emerging regional structures is in West Asia.

The Israeli attack on Gaza was initially seen as a response to the shocking Hamas terror strike on 7 October 2023, which left over 1,200 persons dead, mostly civilians, over 5,000 injured and some 250 taken hostage. However, it soon became clear that Israel's war was actually a genocidal assault on Palestinians in Gaza. Till date, over 74,000 Palestinians have been killed, mostly women and children. Many more have died through starvation and disease, lacking proper food, sanitation or shelter due to an Israeli blockade of aid. Taken along with continuing attacks on Palestinians and their properties in the West Bank by Israeli settlers, implicitly encouraged by the Israeli government, what we are seeing is a rollout of the extreme right-wing



agenda of 'Greater Israel' that would occupy Palestinian land 'from the river to the sea' (and perhaps beyond the Jordan River too). A ceasefire brokered by Qatar, Türkiye and Egypt, backed by the US, in October 2025 stopped large-scale killing, though the bombing, drone attacks and sniping have not completely stopped. A 15-point peace plan brokered by US President Donald Trump's Board of Peace, and supported by the United Nations, was accepted by Hamas on 30 July 2026. It envisages administration of Gaza by Palestinian technocrats and a phased disarming of Hamas calibrated with the withdrawal of Israeli Defence Forces. But Israel rejected the proposal.

Meanwhile, Israel launched a direct attack on Iran in June 2025, with the US joining Israel in bombing Iranian nuclear facilities in Fordow, Isfahan and Natanz. This was a prelude to the launch of a full-scale war on Iran by the US-Israel alliance on 28 February 2026. Iran responded by broadening the conflict to a regional war, striking US bases and vital infrastructure in all countries across West Asia allied with the US, Iran's ally Hezbollah attacked Israel from Southern Lebanon. The regime in Iran has not only survived the war but maintained a blockade of Hormuz. This has severely affected Gulf exporters and other countries.

Iran's successful resistance is attributable to the tenacity of its people and the survival of a harsh regime. But it has also been quietly helped by China and Russia. The audacious aggression of Israel on the other side has been enabled by massive US support: financial, military and diplomatic. Israel has also cleverly leveraged Shia-Sunni rival-

ries in West Asia to initiate US-supported alliances with Sunni countries against a Shia Iran—the Abraham Accords.

That situation is now changing. US allies in the region have realized that the US cannot offer them much protection, while Iran's stature has grown following its successful resistance. Leading Sunni powers in the region, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Egypt, may join other Sunni countries to seek accommodation with Iran, building on the China-brokered restoration of diplomatic ties between Riyadh and Tehran in 2023. Meanwhile, rising US public resentment against the Iran war has led to some rethinking in America about unconditional support for Israel. Pushing Netanyahu aside, the US accepted a temporary peace deal with Iran brokered by Pakistan. Occasional violations notwithstanding, a tense peace prevails.

Meanwhile Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye have announced the Makkah Agreement. A joint statement indicates agreement that an attack on any one country will be considered an attack against all three. The three partners also aim to jointly develop defence capability and collective security. This marks a major shift in West Asian geopolitics. Henceforth, US allies in the region are likely to be guided more by their own security concerns than US interests. Washington's influence in the region is likely to moderate, while that of China may rise, Pakistan being its closest ally in this part of the world. Israel's aggressive ambitions will be curbed and, hopefully, so will Shia-Sunni rivalries, giving peace and prosperity a chance.

This is the first of a two-part series.

THEIR VIEW

The rupee has stabilized but key vulnerabilities remain

SAUMITRA BHADURI



is professor, Madras School of Economics

The rupee's recent stability has brought relief, having earlier hit a record low. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) deserves credit for taking decisive action. It reportedly sold about \$7 billion in one of its largest foreign-exchange interventions in recent months to prevent disorderly depreciation. It supplemented this intervention with a special foreign currency non-resident (FCNR-B) deposit scheme that included a concessional dollar-rupee swap facility announced on 8 June.

As of 21 August, banks had mobilized more than \$65 billion through this window. Total foreign-currency inflows via the new facility, including external commercial borrowings and the overseas foreign-currency class of loans, reached nearly \$73 billion. At a time when the rupee was under pressure, this has been read as a vote of confidence. Meanwhile, India's foreign exchange reserves have risen sharply to \$717 billion, providing RBI with a substantially larger buffer to intervene in the currency market

and contain excessive volatility. Nonetheless, exchange rate stability should not be mistaken for exchange rate strength.

The FCNR-B scheme is an effective crisis-management tool, but it is not a permanent solution. Its large inflows led RBI to announce the scheme's premature closure by end-August, even as competition among banks to attract these deposits intensified, pushing up the scheme's funding costs. Letting the scheme continue would have become progressively more expensive and may have distorted bank funding structures.

The underlying vulnerabilities remain. The first is geopolitical. Any prolonged disruption around the Strait of Hormuz would push up crude oil prices, widening India's import bill and sharply increasing demand for dollars. Given India's dependence on imported energy, the rupee continues to carry a significant oil risk.

The second vulnerability is the nature of capital inflows. Foreign portfolio investment has recovered in recent weeks, but such capital is inherently volatile. Unlike foreign direct investment (FDI), it responds quickly to changes in global risk appetite rather than domestic fundamentals. Foreign portfolio investors had pulled roughly \$28 billion out of Indian equities despite bringing in a net

\$2.1 billion in July. But that still represents a modest reversal relative to the vast exodus seen through March-June. So, it is too early to view this as a return of foreign investors.

Ironically, the improvement in portfolio flows may owe less to developments in India than to those abroad. For almost two years, global investors poured enormous sums into artificial intelligence (AI)-related stocks, particularly in the US. Investors are now assessing whether that extraordinary AI investment will generate equally extraordinary earnings. As enthusiasm moderates, global capital is searching for markets where valuations are more closely aligned with economic fundamentals. India, with one of the fastest-growing large economies and relatively resilient corporate earnings, has therefore become attractive again.

But this window may prove temporary. A much larger force is quietly emerging in Washington. Federal Reserve chair Kevin Warsh has constituted a Balance Sheet Pol-

icy Task Force co-led by former RBI governor Raghuram Rajan to re-assess the future of quantitative easing (QE) as a policy. The implications extend beyond the US. For nearly 15 years, QE flooded global markets with dollar liquidity, much of which flowed into emerging market debt and equity. India

was among the beneficiaries of this exceptionally cheap capital.

If the Fed goes for an aggressive balance sheet reduction, global liquidity will tighten. Higher US Treasury yields would raise the opportunity cost of investing in emerging markets while increasing the cost of external borrowing for Indian firms. The US Treasury's decision to double its buybacks of longer-dated securities could ease global credit costs to an extent. However, if the bond market resists yield-curve management and US yields stay elevated, dollar assets could stay attractive enough to keep pressure on capital flows to emerging markets like India while keeping their external debt costs high as well.

The Reserve Bank of India's special steps offer relief but don't address risks at the structural level

MINT CURATOR

Bitcoin still hasn't fulfilled the promise of whoever crafted it

It has a truly compelling role neither as a currency nor as an asset



EMILY NICOLLE
writes about digital finance for Bloomberg Opinion.



A decentralized currency has not been the liberator it was hyped as. REUTERS

Bitcoin just notched its biggest weekly gain in more than three years, putting an end to a summer of stagnation. Crypto traders can thank US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, whose plan to boost bond buybacks spurred the move. But it will take more than that to return this market to genuinely bullish territory.

The 23% jump was largely down to Bitcoin's part in the 'dollar debasement' trade, an occasional flight to alternative assets prompted by worries about America's heavy borrowing and the White House's eccentric policymaking. Bessent's intervention deepened these fears, although the world's largest cryptocurrency has already started to plateau again after topping \$80,000 last week. Investors are right to be cautious. The experience of October's brutal Bitcoin sell-off, after it hit a peak of more than \$126,000, showed why narratives about what powers its value often fail to stick.

Some traders have persistently touted crypto as an effective dollar hedge alongside the markets' perennial haven, gold. But October's big crash—when Bitcoin slumped more than 12% after US President Donald Trump renewed tariff threats against China—put paid to that idea. Gold, meanwhile, rose to a record high.

Bitcoin has long been in search of an established story to show that it has fundamental worth, and is not just a pure speculative asset—a hunt that has become more necessary since it entered its teenage years and piqued the interest of heavyweight institutional money managers. It is telling that it still hasn't settled on a consistent or persuasive narrative.

A digital version of gold is the typical rationale for Bitcoin fanatics, who also position it as a hedge against rising inflation. As in October, that idea hasn't borne much fruit this year. The price of gold is up more than 7% so far in 2026. Bitcoin is down nearly 10% even after the recent bounce.

And last week's jump, where both gold and Bitcoin rose handsomely, hardly provides an apple-to-apple comparison. Much of the crypto surge was down to traders who had been betting on the price falling and hadn't anticipated a turnaround. They were then forced to buy crypto to cover their short positions. Gold just performed as you would expect. A leading Bitcoin bull, Strategy Inc chairman Michael Saylor urged traders to buy more of the digital currency during the spike, while refraining from adding to his company's own stash.

The prospect of favourable regulation is another popular tale that's used to console Bitcoin fans. Trump loves digital assets; he

has launched several crypto ventures in his second term and pressured Congress to pass legislation last year on stablecoins, which are often backed by the dollar. All of that has helped benefit the president. He reported at least \$1.4 billion in crypto-related earnings in 2025, by far his largest source of income. It included more than \$594 million in sales by World Liberty Financial, a company he co-founded with his sons that has its own dollar-pegged coin.

His meeting with crypto executives shortly after Bessent's bombshell on bond buying last week looked like happy timing. It bolstered the price of Bitcoin at an opportune moment.

Trump's attention has now turned to the US Clarity Act, a market-structure bill that promises to provide the guardrails needed to encourage greater crypto adoption on Wall Street. But the actions of lawmakers and regulators can be unpredictable at the best of times. The bill's progress has stalled, not least because of infighting over ethics provisions that would limit Trump's own involvement in the sector. The US Senate is not expected to revisit the legislation until mid-September, leaving little time for full approval before November's mid-term elections.

And absent from any of the above is a real knockout story that sets crypto apart from other assets in a way that matches the claims of its pioneers. Bitcoin began as a way to liberate money from the grasp of traditional financial systems, a decentralized form of digital cash that would prioritize privacy and equal access above everything else. That promise continues to go unfulfilled. People still prefer to use stablecoins or real-world cash and equivalents to actually buy things. Attempts to kickstart a Bitcoin-only economy have been largely abandoned.

And yet, there is no shame in taking Bitcoin at face value. Every asset starts somewhere, and even gold had to start its journey as a medium of exchange a couple of millennia or more ago.

Maybe the cryptocurrency will achieve all the dreams its pseudonymous creator Satoshi Nakamoto hoped for. Or it could remain just as it is today: a tool for speculation that provides a chance to make some money—as long as your stomach for risk is strong enough to bear it. ©BLOOMBERG

The key to a killer résumé is your perfect eggs

In a cutthroat market, lawyers and bankers list quirky side pursuits like training miniature dachshunds and building birdhouses

Jamie Waters

Last year, Kate Reder Sheikh placed dozens of associates and counsels at white-shoe law firms across the Bay Area and Colorado. Some of their résumés stood out—but not for the honors they graduated with.

Beneath the prestigious firms, bar admissions and T14 law schools, the applicants listed additional skills. Training miniature dachshunds. Building birdhouses. And, in the case of one counsel, “perfecting restaurant-quality scrambled eggs.”

These are the kinds of details that could make a hiring manager think “Yes, this is somebody I’d like to be in the trenches with at 3 o’clock in the morning on a deadline,” said Reder Sheikh, a partner at Major, Lindsey & Africa, a global legal-recruiting agency.

In a cutthroat white-collar talent market, where AI looms as a job-security threat, some recruiters are encouraging job seekers to get ahead by emphasizing decidedly human qualities like a canasta addiction or a weakness for pickling vegetables.

Advocates say an offbeat pastime can tempt a glassy-eyed recruiter to reread your application and serve as an icebreaker in interviews. Reder Sheikh said more than half the associates she placed last year listed hobbies—a jump from a few years ago.

This trend chimes with the Gen Z and millennial mantra to bring your “whole, authentic self” to work, said Rebecca Thornton, a partner at talent advisory firm Spencer Stuart in New York. It also dovetails with a rise in corporate leaders undoing a couple of buttons when marketing themselves online—whether that’s Sequoia



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Capital partners citing Pink Floyd and Rhodan Ridgebacks on company bios, or Blackstone President and COO Jon Gray’s viral (and very wobbly) selfie videos, in which he offers market advice and general musings while out jogging.

“AI is pushing out résumés that all look the same,” said Richard King, who runs a Los Angeles-based corporate recruitment company. “Let’s bring the human back.”

Listing hobbies and interests was fairly common until the mid-2010s, when recruiters told candidates to remove any references to noncore skills amid efforts to reduce bias in hiring, said King. Today, folks on social media debate the merits of including off-duty pursuits, with opponents calling it cringe, irrelevant or amateurish.

The topic shot to prominence in January

when a (now-deleted) post on X about hiring for a banking role went viral. “I reviewed a résumé that listed ‘olive oil’ as an interest,” wrote the anonymous poster, who did not respond to a request for comment. “That is not an interest. It’s been hours and I cannot stop thinking about it. There will not be an interview.” Many came to Interested in Olive Oil’s defense, calling the reference refreshingly

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Fred Cibelli, a technology principal at EY in New York, said that, assuming the candidate fulfilled the job requirements, he would want to hear about their regard for olive oil in an interview. “There’s only so many times you can talk about what’s going on with open versus closed models in AI,” he said. He has noticed a small increase in hobbies appearing on LinkedIn pro-

files and résumés lately and said he would like to see more.

Deciding what to include is another matter. When applying for a role at Meta (then Facebook) several years ago, Dawn Choo, a data scientist, debated whether to mention under “Fun Facts” that she once performed in the Washington Ballet’s “Nutcracker.” Though ballet handily evokes discipline, Choo wondered if she wanted to include something “that feels so girly, that leans into my feminine side,” when the tech world is male-dominated. Choo, who’s 35 and now runs her own company in Tennessee, ultimately included it, and said she only received positive reactions. (She also got the job.)

Hobbyists aren’t just peppering their résumés with any old activity. There are rules. This section should always come at the end, and take up one line only, said Reder Sheikh. Ideally, the hobby hints at a quality that’s beneficial in the workplace, such as organizational skills or grit, said Thornton. Most importantly: Don’t you dare be vague.

People will write, “sports, music or food”—yeah, every single person on planet Earth is interested in [those] things,” said Jack Kolb, a 24-year-old financial analyst in Chicago. A few years ago, as the president of the Investment Banking Academy at University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, Kolb helped fellow students apply for banking jobs. He urged everyone to list specific interests that showed personality.

“I believe it’s one of the most, if not the most important line [on a résumé] for a qualified candidate” trying to break into investment banking, he said. When bankers are deciding which students to do networking calls with, he said, they’re thinking, “If I agree to a call with this kid, am I going to be bored to death?”

Kolb said his own résumé-worthy interests include extreme skiing, Chicago Blackhawks hockey, Chipotle and “The Office” (favorite character: Michael Scott). Another guy at the banking academy, a cheeky strawberry-blond, listed “red hair” as an interest. A third: hot-dog-eating contests.

All got jobs.

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MONDAY MOTIVATION

‘Productivity is about focus, not volume’

PadelPark’s Nikhil Sachdev on taking the sport to the masses in India

Shail Desai

The first time he played padel, Nikhil Sachdev was hooked. The competitive nature of the sport was one aspect of it, the social appeal was another. When he jumped into the research, it was evident that the game was relatively new in India. He had his task cut out if he wanted to take it to the masses.

“The biggest challenge early on was awareness. While starting out, it was less about spotting a trend and more about committing to something before the trend existed,” says Mumbai-based Sachdev, 44, co-founder of PadelPark India. Sachdev talks to *Mint* about mentorship and why he likes early mornings.

Who do you consider your mentor?

I’ve learned from different people at different stages of my life. Each one has influenced a different aspect of how I think. I don’t look at mentorship as a fixed relationship—it’s more about being open to absorbing perspectives from people who have operated at different levels or navigated similar challenges.

One major insight you worked on with your mentor’s guidance?

One key insight that has stayed with me is to focus on building long-term value, rather than chasing short-term wins. In a space like padel where growth is visible in phases, it’s easy to focus on short-term wins. But the real impact comes from decisions that compound over time, even if they don’t show immediate results.

What’s your morning schedule like?

I like to start my day early and keep it structured, usually with some form of physical activity. It helps create a mental reset before the day begins. In a business that’s growing quickly, that initial structure helps bring clarity before things get reactive.

What are the productivity principles that you follow?

The biggest shift has been understanding that productivity is about focus, not volume. In a growing business like PadelPark, there are always multiple moving parts. Being clear about what actually drives progress is critical.

Monday Motivation is a series in which business leaders discuss their mentors and their work ethics.

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